



PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

THIRD MEETING, 2025

Wednesday, 12th November, 2025

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 2:58 p.m.*

[THE SPEAKER, RT HON ALBAN
SUMANA KINGSFORD BAGBIN, IN
THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

The Speaker: Hon Members, we would take the item numbered 5, Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS
AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

The Speaker: We will start with the Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* of Tuesday, 11th November, 2025.

Page 1...8—

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, with respect, let me bring your attention to the page under review which is the page numbered 8, the item numbered 5 (b), line 2. I submit that after the word “Ahanta West”, we delete “Municipality” and replace same with “Constituency”. On the grounds of

consistency, every visitor that comes to the House is benchmarked against the Constituency they are coming from.

The Speaker: Hon Member, we are dealing with the minutes of what took place on Tuesday, 11th November, 2025 and that was what actually took place. The name that was submitted to me was “Ahanta West Municipal”. In my pronunciation, I stated “Ahanta West Municipality” and that was what happened and I think that is what has been captured.

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, respectfully, not to litigate. My point is that for the sake of consistency, if you look at all other visitors, the reference point has always been their Constituency, so if we could replace “Municipality” with “Constituency”. Because these assembly persons arguably work at the various district or municipal assemblies. But in this House, the one who represents them is on the ticket of a Constituency—but everything stops with you, the Speaker. This is my prayer, if it finds favour with you.

3:08 p.m.

The Speaker: Everything does not stop with me. It is who sponsored them here.

They came and submitted that they came under the authority of the assembly, not constituency and that is what they submitted through the officers

to me. So that is what we will capture. By the time we realised, it was the assembly that sponsored them to come and that will be under the district or municipality. That is what we captured.

If it is the MP, and you are the MP who sponsored them to be here, that is under your authority and you want to take advantage, say so, then we can look at it. Maybe when it comes to the *Official Report*, we would try to capture that but this is what happened on Tuesday and that is what has been captured by the Clerks-at-the-Table. So, let us proceed on that.

Page 8...19.

Hon Members, in the absence of any correction, the *Votes and Proceedings* of the 13th Sitting, dated Tuesday, 11th November, 2025, is adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Hon Members, I do not have any copy of the *Official Report*. So, we will proceed to the next item.

Yes, Hon Deputy Minority Whip?

First Deputy Minority Whip (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I rise under Order 67 (2). I read;

“The Order of Business set out in the Order Paper may, by leave of the Speaker, be varied at any sitting.”

Mr Speaker, I rise to appeal that you vary the Order of Business. Then we can move to Statements. That is the item

numbered 7 on page 3 of today's *Order Paper*.

Mr Speaker, if your leave is granted under Order 67(2), the Minority Chief Whip will now be fortified under Order 93(1).

Mr Speaker, with your leave, I read Order 93(1);

“By the indulgence of the House and leave of the Speaker, a Member may explain a matter of personal nature or make a Statement on a matter of urgent public importance, at the time appointed for Statements under Order 67.”

Mr Speaker, I so submit, as there is an urgent matter of public importance that the Minority Chief Whip wishes to make.

Thank you.

The Speaker: Leave is granted. Yes, Majority Leader?

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, there has been some discussion between the two Sides, and this request is supported by the Majority, except to say that the discussion is to the effect that both Sides will make a Statement on that subject matter. So, when the leave is granted, it should be granted so that both Sides of the House will be granted leave to make Statements on the same subject matter.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Leave is granted for the Minority Chief Whip to proceed to make the Statement.

STATEMENTS

A Call for the Immediate Suspension of the Ghana Armed Forces Recruitment Process

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh (NPP — Nsawam/Adoagyiri): Mr Speaker, I am humbled and grateful for the leave granted, and I thank Leadership for the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, it is with deep concern and sorrow that I make this important Statement to recognise the impact of the tragic incident that has been reported in our media space just this morning, the death of some six potential recruits for the Ghana Armed Forces (GAF), which took place at the El-Wak Sports Stadium in Accra.

Mr Speaker, indeed, as has been confirmed by the Ghana Armed Forces in its press statement issued this morning, we have all been caused to recline to mourning. Our heavy hearts go out to the families of those victims, including the several others who have been injured on various levels of severity and receiving treatment. Mr Speaker, at the hearing of this news, I thought of the words of Shakespeare in *The Tempest* when he said; “We are such staff as

dreams are made on; and our little life is rounded with a sleep”

These victims were once among thousands of Ghanaians waiting for the opportunity to join the Ghana Armed Forces, but met their fate in such an unfortunate event. This is no small matter to shelve, and as concerned and indeed affected leaders, we must move to restore hope in our people, even in the time of grief.

Mr Speaker, the grief heightened when other reports came indicating that the death toll was now at least 12 persons. It then came clearly to me that we must act immediately to resolve the risks associated with such recruitment processes which have lingered too long a time. I resolved to make this important call as first step to immediately suspend the recruitment process for the time. We also must urgently ensure that the process be decentralised, or further decentralised, to address the excessively large crowds as well as the other risks faced by people travelling from various parts of the country. As an arm of Government, we urgently need the Deputy Minister for Defence, under the circumstance, to come to the House and brief the people on what alternative measures will be employed to deal with such risks.

Mr Speaker, this is not merely a tragic accident. It is a profound and systemic failure and indictment of a system that has lost its effectiveness. This sad news

from El-Wak is a deafening wake-up call. It is a direct sermon to the Ghana Armed Forces, the Ministry of Defence, and the nation at large. The question is no longer about protocol or procedure. It is about humanity and leadership.

Mr Speaker, in the spirit of patriotism, I am the begging need to honour those bold, hopeful victims whose spirits led them only to the brink of true service to their nation, Ghana. We must review the existing practice relating to this recruitment.

Let us bear in mind that a greater blow to our nation will be the day that men and women refuse to enlist because of the many challenges the service agencies' recruitments are plagued with.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, my call is simple and devoid of ill will to any agency of the State, but rather an advocacy for the teeming youth who will today or tomorrow be faced with the same risks. Let it not be said that we looked on with heavy hearts and folded our arms.

Mr Speaker, I am grateful.

The Speaker: Hon Members, from what I have here, the next Hon Member who is to comment on the Statement is Mr Eric Agbana. By our Standing Orders, when a Statement is read, the other Members are to comment on it, Order 93(4). You are to do that within a limited time, because all the comments

that we would listen to should not exceed one hour. So, by the Standing Orders, your comments should not exceed five minutes. You may do so now.

3:18 p.m.

Mr Eric Edem Agbana (NDC — Ketu North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. This is an urgent Statement on the unfortunate tragic stampede at the El-Wak Sports Stadium earlier this morning.

Mr Speaker, I rise this afternoon with deep sorrow to draw the attention of this House to the tragic stampede that occurred earlier today at the El-Wak Sports Stadium in Accra during the ongoing Ghana Armed Forces recruitment exercise.

Reports indicate that some potential recruits lost their lives while many others sustained various degrees of injury in their attempt to go through the screening process for enlistment into the Ghana Armed Forces.

Mr Speaker, this incident is a national tragedy. It is a painful reminder of the risk and desperation that many of our young people face in search of opportunities to serve and contribute to the development of our nation. No one deserves to die in seeking for an opportunity to serve the badge of this country. These were young people, patriotic citizens, responding to a national call to duty. Their only desire was to serve Ghana under the flag with loyalty and pride.

I extend my heartfelt condolences to the bereaved families and loved ones of all who lost their lives in this unfortunate event. To those who sustained injuries, we pray for their full recovery and our thoughts and sympathies are with them in this difficult period.

Mr Speaker, I wish to commend His Excellency President John Dramani Mahama for his swift and compassionate response. His prompt visit to the 37 Military Hospital demonstrates true leadership and empathy. It sends a powerful message that the Government stands firmly with victims and their families in this difficult time.

I also acknowledge the efforts of the Ghana Armed Forces, the Ghana Police Service, the National Ambulance Service and the dedicated medical professionals who responded quickly to the emergency and worked tirelessly to save many more lives.

Mr Speaker, we cannot treat this as an isolated incident. There must be a full-scale investigation into the circumstances surrounding the tragedy, from crowd management and planning to logistics and coordination. We must establish accountability and ensure that the systemic failures that led to this incident are decisively addressed. If anyone slept on their job, they must be sanctioned accordingly. The findings of this investigation should guide immediate and practical reforms in the recruitment processes of our security institutions.

Mr Speaker, it is time to rethink the centralised mode of conducting these recruitment exercises. The days of

assembling thousands of young applicants in a single venue must end. We must further decentralise the process and adopt a data-driven, technology-enabled system that allows applicants to be screened and processed in badges across various regions. This approach will enhance transparency, efficiency, and more importantly, safety while preserving the dignity of our young people.

Finally, Mr Speaker, this tragedy must awaken our collective conscience as a nation. It calls for a renewed commitment to creating decent and sustainable jobs for our young people so that desperation does not push them into unsafe situations. Let this not be another headline that fades away. Let it be a turning point that compels us to act responsibly, humanely and with urgency towards our young citizens. I humbly call on you to direct the relevant Committees of Parliament to look into this tragedy.

May the souls of the departed rest in perfect peace, and may our nation learn and rise stronger from this painful loss.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Joseph Kwame Kumah (NDC — Kintampo North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to have a bite on these Statements ably made by the Hon Members in this House, Mr Annoh-Dompreh and Mr Edem Agbana. I also add my voice to console parents who have lost their loved ones at this moment unexpectedly. And for the injured, may the good Lord heal them fast for us.

Mr Speaker, I am sure it is good to put in it on record. I was just monitoring the news and I can on authority say that at 37 Military Hospital, the Officer in-charge, confirmed that there are about six lives lost. Also, 12 are in critical condition instead of the 12 lives that people are speculating have been lost. By the grace of God, they are responding to treatment. So, let us have the records right. I would also indicate that ideally, it should have been decentralised. I just called one of the officers I know and I have been informed that at El-Wak Sports Stadium, there are about 22,000 young people looking for the job. In Tamale, there are about 5,000 people. In Bono and Ahafo combined, there are about 8,000 people. So, in totality, without Bono-East, there are about 50,000 youthful able-bodied men looking for non-existing jobs. This also tells us that, as a country, we have not been fair to the youth. Let us think in that direction.

There are 55,000 people looking for jobs, which means they have not been in employment and that is what it means —

The Speaker: Hon Member?

Mr Kumah: Yes, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Please, we operate within our rules. The Standing Orders do not permit what you are saying now. This is a Statement. Yesterday, I used a term and many of you reacted privately. I used the term “confirmation bias”. Before I allowed the commentary, I read the rules of the House to you. You have all ignored the rules and what you have in your heads, you are telling us, which are

not in the letter or spirit of the rules. Even my Son, Mr Agbana, also decided to tell us what he has already got and not according to the rules.

I stated clearly that when a Statement is read, the rest that follow are comments, but he also started reading a Statement. Now, those comments are not to provoke debate. They are to be restricted to facts. Commentary on Statements should not generate debate. You do not talk about things that are controversial.

Please, the rules are clear on this, and I told you it should not exceed five minutes. So, please, wind up.

Mr Kumah: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I am guided.

So, Mr Speaker, by this, I add my voice to console the bereaved families and to also wish those who are injured well. Mr Speaker, I am grateful for your guidance.

3:28 p.m.

Mr Kofi Amankwa-Manu (NPP — Atwima Kwanwoma): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to add my voice to what one of the makers of the Statement termed as a national tragedy.

Indeed, it is a national tragedy and I wish to sincerely thank the makers of the Statement.

Mr Speaker, hitherto, all those wanting to be recruited into the Ghana Armed Forces had to gather at El-Wak

Sports Stadium, but it became necessary for us to decentralise the whole process. In fact, the very first time I heard of the decentralisation of the process, I thought that finally, we had gotten it right. But here we are, faced with the same problem.

Mr Speaker, one of the makers of the Statement said that this is a turning point for this country to do things right. Indeed, it is a turning point for us to do things right. I believe that all of us must put our shoulders to the wheel. We cannot continue to see our sons and daughters who want to serve this country perish this way. It is rather a sad story. I am a father and if my son or daughter wanting to serve this country by wearing the uniform perish this way, it will definitely break me down. We all need to come together as a House to support, not only the Ghana Armed Forces, but any recruiting agency or institution so that we do not face a situation like this again.

Mr Speaker, just yesterday, a report was released on the perishing of our dear ones through a helicopter crash. Today, it is a different story. We do not know what will happen tomorrow. But I believe sincerely that if we all put our shoulders to the wheel, we will find a lasting solution to this problem. It is indeed a national tragedy that we will never want to see again, and the only way we will not witness this situation is when we come together to find a lasting solution.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, let me thank the makers of this Statement for the wonderful piece given to us.

Mr James Agalga (NDC — Builsa North): Mr Speaker, thank you for giving me the opportunity to comment on the Statement ably made by our two Colleagues.

I would like to also express profound sorrow at the death of six of our compatriots who went to the El-Wak Sports Stadium this morning in order that they could be selected to join our Armed Forces. That said, I would want to quickly commend the Commander-in-Chief of the Armed Forces, President Mahama, for swiftly responding to the crisis by visiting the wounded at the 37 Military Hospital this morning. In fact, His Excellency the President did not only visit 37 Military Hospital to commiserate with the families of the deceased and also to console the wounded, he immediately ordered that the process be halted at the El-Wak Sports stadium. So, I want to assure the Hon Minority Chief Whip who, in his Statement, called for the halting of the process to pave way for investigations; that that has already been done. So, as we speak, there is no recruitment exercise ongoing at the El-Wak Sports Stadium.

Mr Speaker, the maker of the Statement, the Hon Minority Chief Whip, also alluded to the fact that there is need for further decentralisation. I just want to place on record that for a very long time, the recruitment process was centralised. It took the intervention of this Government to revert to the old system of having the process decentralised. *[Uproar]*

Mr Speaker—

The Speaker: Hon Member, you are factually incorrect.

Mr Agalga: Mr Speaker, my take is that for a long time, the decentralised character of recruitment had been shelved and that it was in recent times, under this particular dispensation, the decision to revert to the old system came into being.

The Speaker: Hon Member, make comments; do not raise issues that are debatable. Let us comment and move on.

Mr Agalga: Mr Speaker, I take a cue.

Mr Speaker, let me further touch on another issue which has to do with the crowds that poured out at the various recruitment centres. I ask myself, why would this happen even when the process has been heavily decentralised to the extent that as we speak, across all regional capitals, the same exercise is ongoing. Could it be that since 2021, the Ghana Armed Forces did not advertise for recruitment and that once the adverts were made, this time around, a lot of the youth who are unemployed thought that this is an opportunity to at least put themselves up for recruitment? Because since 2021, we have not had the situation whereby the whole process was advertised in a transparent manner and people asked to report at the various training centres for recruitment. That is a question I ask.

Mr Speaker, be that as it may, I support the calls for this matter to be thoroughly investigated in order to ensure that we do not have a future

reoccurrence of the tragedy that happened today.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

The Speaker: Yes, Mr Dominic Nitiwul?

Mr Dominic Bingab Aduna Nitiwul (NPP — Bimbilla): Mr Speaker, let me take this opportunity to sincerely sympathise with the families of the people who lost their lives in these tragic circumstances. Indeed, these young people went out to look for a job for themselves, only to find themselves in the mortuary. The last thing we can do is to politicise their deaths. It is very painful because if one were a family member, one would be very sad to see somebody trying to politicise this. So, I will not, and I do not expect any Member to do that.

Mr Speaker, the military had never, not under my watch or under Hon Benjamin Bewa-Nyog Kunbuor, Hon Mark Owen Woyongo, Hon Albert Kan-Dapaah, Hon Kwame Addo-Kufuor, or any former Ministers of Defence, deviated from what they are currently doing. They have always gone to the regional capitals to do exactly what is being done now. We did that in 2017 and 2021. At no point did the military deviate from that exercise. I just want to make that correction. It has always been the same thing.

There are two forms of getting people into the military. It is called enlistment when it has to do with the officers and

recruitment for the recruits. The current system is recruitment. Every year, we enlist people into the military, that is, the officers corps. But for the recruitment, once people apply and they qualify, we do not want to waste the time of the Ghanaian youth to keep applying every year only to collect money from them. We do not want to do that. So we do it biennially or sometimes annually.

Mr Speaker, as we see today, I can tell you that about 20,000 young people applied and qualified. Meanwhile, the military is going to take only 4,000 of them. This current recruitment is just 4,000. The Accra Centre alone has more than 5,000 applicants. That is the difficulty that we face.

The Speaker: Hon Member, with this information, I can tell you are speculating. Let us move away from that.

3:38 p.m.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, I know what I am talking about. I will take your guidance but it is the truth.

I am saying that I support the call to halt the process, not just at El-Wak Sports Stadium, but the entire recruitment process to look at the exercise and give ourselves some time to find out what is happening. That is the first thing I would suggest.

Mr Speaker, the second thing is a military reform because we have not seen this for a long time. People get bruises, but to have people dying, and we

just continue as if nothing has happened, is not good. So I will support that call. I would also support the call for the Ag Minister for Defence, and I am choosing my words well, not the Deputy Minister, the Ag Minister for Defence, to come and brief this House. Not just on this isolated issue, this is a very serious matter, but on the incident that happened in Obuasi, where seven to eight lives were lost.

Even when the most unfortunate incident happened and the Minister lost his life, Mr Speaker, I do not remember the Ag Minister coming to brief you and this House on the incident. But now that the Report is out, I think that they should combine all this and brief the House properly on these three things: the Obuasi incident, the issue of what has just happened today, and the military Z9 helicopter incident. They should brief this House properly and tell us what is happening, so that we can be seen as representatives of the people who engage in what is going on.

Mr Speaker, I say this with a heavy heart, because I just left that Ministry after spending eight years. God being gracious to me, things like this did not happen under my watch. So, I will urge the Minister to come. If you remember, when young soldiers reported in war, and the following day they went out brutalising people, I came to this House to brief the House. When the punishment was meted out, I came back to brief this

House again. So, Mr Speaker, there is a precedent.

The Speaker: Just a minute, Majority Leader. I am really watching the time. Yes.

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Mr Speaker, when we met this morning at Conclave, the Minority came to lobby that they had a Statement on the incident. And I indicated to them that the Ministry had plans to come and brief the House. But they insisted on varying the Order of Business so that they could make the Statement.

Mr Speaker, if we had been patient, we would have actually received the Minister at Statement Time to make the Statement even before these statements were made. So, I want to assure him that the Ag Minister for Defence, that is the Minister for Finance, is on his way here to make a Statement to this House. So please exercise a little patience, and very soon the Ag Minister for Defence will be in this House.

The Speaker: Minority Leader.

Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, lately we have been receiving a lot of tutorials on the Rules of this House from the respected Majority Leader.

Mr Speaker, with respect, I submit most humbly that what he just did was not a point of order. When the Leader of

the House chooses convenience over principle, it becomes worrying. It is becoming very convenient that the Leader of the House is very intolerant of views that are expressed by this Side of the House, and he finds ways to come through a supposed point of order and even issue threats.

Mr Speaker, this must stop. As and when it pleases the Majority Leader, he uses the Rules to stop people from expressing their opinions. This is the House of Parliament. We do not have any problem at all if the strict practice is that we must follow the Rules. It will be an opportunity for us to learn. But he who comes to equity must do equity.

Enough of this, Mr Speaker. And I humbly beg that if he is talking about rules, he should practice them. What is happening in this House is amounting to the Majority Leader using the back door to introduce a certain culture of silence; to silence the views of the Minority. That is what he is doing. So that he would intervene to stop one's thought pattern and have his way. Instead of patiently waiting for his time to make his own views known. This must stop. It must not come from the Leader of the House.

The Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, it is obvious that the Minority Leader has issues. And I think, like the Speaker said last week, when we were discussing football, somebody jumped to discuss *ampe*.

Mr Speaker, if we review the cameras, we will see that the Deputy Whip at the beginning walked to and pleaded with me to allow him to vary the order of Business so that Hon Annoh-Dompreh would make the Statement. He came here and pleaded with me. The cameras bear testimony.

Mr Speaker, at that point, if I wanted to silence the Minority, I would have told him that I would not allow him to vary the order of Business because the Minister is coming here. I would have opposed the application for the variation.

[Uproar]

3:48 p.m.

The Speaker: Hon Member, what are you doing? Please, you can heckle a Colleague, but you do not use your hand and clap. That is noise. You cannot do that. Please, Hon Members, today, you started on a very good note, calling on us to work together.

Please, the Hon Member for Atwima Kwanwoma, Mr Kofi Amankwa-Manu spoke very well here and I got a response calling on us and all Ghanaians to work together. Meanwhile, you seated here cannot work together. Differences are natural. It depends on how you express the differences. What you do here is to try to persuade. You do not persuade a person by shouting at the person. You have to use a voice modulated in a way. The tone of your voice, your choice of

words, and how you express yourself is what convinces the person. You only do that when you visit boys or girls. *[Laughter]* But, you are here. You are not only talking to your Colleague here; you are talking to the whole country. Why?

We are faced with a very sad occasion. Again, it is not words; it is actions. Let the Ghanaian people see that really it is shocking, you are sad, and that you want to do something about it. This is not an issue you should use for politics at all, please.

The Speaker should not participate in debate, but the Speaker is not among the three monkeys: see no evil, speak no evil, and hear no evil. That is not the role of the Speaker. The national interest and how to protect it prevails. You know that part of our Rules talks about interruption of debates. Go through it in the Standing Orders. One of them is the point of order. Read it. It goes beyond point of order. When you have information and you want to share at the time a Member is talking, you are also allowed to interrupt. Please, let us continue to cooperate and let the good people of Ghana know that we are truly representing them; not political parties.

Hon Member for Bimbilla, you may go on now.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, I am treading a very fine line because I just left the place. The military is a very disciplined institution. I would have wished and prayed that this did not

happen to the Military, but unfortunately, we are where we are now. So, I am treading cautiously. As you also know, most of my predecessors have not had the opportunity to sit in Parliament after leaving that office, so they virtually kept quiet. I have to always mind how I carry out myself because of the position that I held. Mr Speaker, I say and I still repeat that I support the position that we should halt the whole process and review it.

Secondly, I also think that the Hon Minister should come and brief us. I am happy the Hon Minister said he is briefing the House on only this particular thing. But I said that if he briefed us on the three key things that happened, it would have helped us especially the report that just came. It would have helped the nation and all of us because we are representing the people. Once they brief Parliament, we have briefed the nation.

Thirdly, the other security agencies would also do recruitment. It is not just the Military. They have also started advertising and their numbers are even bigger than that of the Military. We anticipate that the problems that we are seeing today, if the Minister for Defence and the Minister for the Interior do not sit to see how they can make sure that they reform the process, we may be getting worse situations. We do not want that to be repeated, so I would urge both Ministers to look at how they will go about their intakes so that we do not get repetition of this kind of disaster any longer.

Lastly, Mr Speaker, this only tells us that we have a big problem in the country; the problem of unemployment. It is a big problem. Mr Speaker, the earlier the political class and the leaders of this nation do something about it, the better for us. If young men—All across the world, it is difficult to get people to serve in the Military. In the United States of America (USA), people literally have to begged to serve in the military. Yet, today, young men and women are all rushing just because they want to serve in the military. I do not know whether they are rushing because of unemployment or it is just the love of serving in the military. But I will lean towards the fact that people want to survive; people want a job. I can say that we have a big problem of unemployment. When these teeming youth between the ages of 21 and 25 years who are outside, complete school and we do not do anything about them, this nation called Ghana may regret one day. I do not know when, but I can say that it is better for the political class to think together—I like the way you say we should work together. We should work together and find a solution to it immediately. Otherwise, we may regret.

Thank you.

The Speaker: Yes, let me hear a female voice.

Hajia Laadi Ayii Ayamba (NDC — Pusiga): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Statement ably made by my Colleagues. I wish to first of all express my condolences to the bereaved families. It

is very painful for our children to go for recruitment only for us to lose them. But I want us to all take solace in the almighty Allah. There is nothing that happens that does not happen at the right time. This is what the almighty Allah has ordained for them. Today is their day. No matter how, no matter what, no matter who was there as what, even if we brought all the presidents of the world to sit there as ministers or whatsoever, once today is ordained for them to die, they will. This is what has happened. *[Uproar]* Unless you do not believe in the oneness of God, and unless you do not believe in the oneness of the almighty Allah. It is not anybody who wanted them to die. There is no single officer there who wanted even one single soul to pass. Not even one person hoped and prayed that one person would die there. Let us understand that. If that were the wish of anybody, I have not seen or thought of that person.

Mr Speaker, I appreciate what you have said. Let us work together. If there are mistakes, let us look into it. I have heard one of my Colleagues say that there are other recruitments that are yet to be done. Yes, that is true. It is a very big lesson, and we use the problems that have occurred or the mistakes that have taken place to correct ourselves and forge ahead. We are sitting here and most probably talking and looking at this with political lenses, but who knows those who have passed? Who knows whether they voted for the National Democratic Congress (NDC), the New Patriotic Party (NPP), the People's National Convention (PNC), or even they never voted? But here we are worried. We are

not happy because we did not wish that and never thought of that. So, let us be conscious of that.

Let me appreciate the President, H.E. John Dramani Mahama, for putting a halt to the activity at the El-Wak Stadium.

3:58 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I wish to suggest that whether now or in the future, decentralisation should be properly done. It could even be done by districts, not regions. If we can go down to the grassroots, it can even be by constituency – after all, they are all Ghanaians, and they are our people – rather than let people travel maybe from Pusiga to Accra to the El-Wak Sports Stadium, only to come and then die when nobody ever dreamt of it.

So, Mr Speaker, I wish to call on all of us to stay united, and to note that we are representatives of everybody, and not one particular person. When something like this happens, we should fight together, forge ahead, look at the best that will lead us on our way forward. I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

The Speaker: Hon Darko-Mensah and Hon Ayew Afriyie, between the two of you, who is the senior? Yes, we will come to you, do not worry. Do you want to yield to him?

Mr Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah (NPP — Takoradi): Thank you, Mr Speaker for this special opportunity—

The Speaker: Sorry, just a minute. Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think I need your guidance in this matter. In the course of the contributions made by Hon Members, they have sought information from Government on what is to be done, what should not be done, and what measures should be implemented among others. Given that the acting Hon Minister for Defence is in the House, I want to find out whether after we have commented on the Statement, if leave is granted by your good self for the Hon Minister to now come and make a Statement, will we again be commenting on the Statement that has been made by the Hon Minister? Or will it be convenient at this stage for us to permit the Hon Minister to make the official Statement that Hon Members have been calling for, after which we can then take on board any information that the Hon Minister may give us, so that we take on board those pieces of information and then continue with the contribution? That is just guidance I am seeking from you, Mr Speaker.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, what we are doing now is guided by Order 93. If the Hon Minister chooses to come before us, he comes here under Order 91. There is no such estoppel rule that would operate against comments by Hon Members under Order 93. If the Hon Minister comes to this House to make a Statement, which Statement would be regulated by Order 91, the rule permits, under Order 91 (4) for Hon Members of this House to make comments.

So, Mr Speaker, with respect and in all humility, I do not think that there is anything at all for your guidance to be sought on. The Hon Majority Leader, most respectfully, must allow the Speaker to guide proceedings under the rules that have been invoked for now. If the Hon Minister later comes to say that he has something to say, nothing stops him; that would also be guided by a different Rule. But to say that he wants to find out whether if the Hon Minister comes and says something, Hon Members would be permitted to make comments, Mr Speaker, would be another speculation that the Rules would not permit. So, Mr Speaker, I beg of the Hon Majority Leader to allow proceedings to go on without any interruption. I so submit.

The Speaker: Hon Members, it is for the reasons that the Hon Minority Leader has just adduced that I wanted clarification whether he was going to make the Statement as the Minister or as a Member of the House. As the Hon Minority Leader stated, they come under two different Standing Orders. If he is making it as a Minister, definitely, Order 91 will apply. If he is making it as a Member, then Order 93 will apply.

Order 91(2) says—Hon Members, please, we need your attention. This is an important matter. Hon Stephen Amoah, are you vexed or are you leaving the premises? You are leaving—Hon Member? *[Laughter]* Hon Members, Order 91 (2) says;

“A Minister of State may make a statement of government policy and the statement shall

- (a) be limited to facts which are necessary to be made known to the House; and
- (b) not contain matters that are likely to provoke debate.”

But if it is a Statement by a Member, because the Statement has already been made by a Member, what he will be allowed to do as a Member is to comment on that Statement, and that will be limited to not exceeding five minutes. If he is making the Statement as a Minister, it is not limited to the five minutes, but it will be limited by Order 91(2) (a) and (b). But for comments, it is the same for Members with regard to Statements by a Minister or Member. It is the same way where you make a Statement in such a way that it does not provoke debate and also does not exceed the five minutes on both occasions. So that is what I wanted to know. Are you going to make the Statement as a Minister or as a Member?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, he will make the Statement as a Minister.

The Speaker: Now, if he is going to make the Statement as a Minister of State and that comes under Order 91 and it is on the same subject, I will then allow him to make that Statement, then we will now continue with the comments by Members. He may disclose some facts which may be necessary to be known by the House and that will guide Members in their comments.

4:08 p.m.

So, the Minister may do so now. Hon Minister, just a minute, my attention has

been drawn to the presence of deaconesses with us. They have another commitment. Let me just recognise their presence and the other visitors; they are just two groups. We have Deaconess Mary Ampah leading a group of women referred to as Area Women Leaders from Sefwi Juaboso. They are from the Church of Pentecost, and they are 54 in number.

Please, on behalf of the House, I warmly welcome you to Parliament. You have a lot of your Members here. The Church of Pentecost has a lot of members as Members of Parliament. We thank you for producing so many Members for the Parliament of Ghana. You are welcome. Please listen, watch their behaviour, and help me to manage them. Thank you so much. You are warmly welcome. Resume your seats.

[Area Women Leaders of the Church of Pentecost from Sefwi Juaboso were acknowledged]

The Speaker: We also have Daniel Bahouli. He is leading a group from Ningo Prampram as the Executive Director. The group is, in fact, written in French; Les Passerelles Gobale, Ghana. They are 96 in number.

You are also warmly welcome. *Bienvenue*. I am sure they are studying in French, and please, you would get the opportunity to teach the Members of Parliament the French Language. Many of them are completely illiterate when it comes to the French Language. I am in a basic school of the French language, so at least I understand something. You are welcome and you may resume your seats.

[Les Passerelles Globale Ghana from Ningo Prampram were acknowledged]

The Speaker: Now, Minister, you may present your Statement. Hon Minister, the Minority Chief Whip is drawing my attention to something. Yes?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, in the spirit of strictly going by the rules, as we have been told by the Majority Leader that the Minister is coming under Order 91, if I may read, Order 91 says:

- “(1) The Speaker may make a statement on any matter of interest to the House.
- (2) A Minister of State may make a statement of government policy and the statement shall
 - (a) be limited to facts which are necessary to be made known to the House; and
 - (b) not contain matters that are likely to provoke debate.”

Mr Speaker, is it the case that our acting Minister for Defence is coming here —

The Speaker: Hon Member, you are completely out of Order. Why? Oh, God. I read the same Standing Orders, referred to the same issues, and drew his attention to that. Now, you are repeating and asking questions. Why? Oh, please, you know how this thing originated. Your Leader was not at Conclave, but you

were present. You came with the Statement to me at the Lobby, and because of the emergency involved, we decided to admit it so that you can make it today. You insisted to vary the order of the Business, and that was conceded to. That is why the Majority Leader even raised the issue that even if we were taking the Business according to how it is captured on the *Order Paper*, the Minister would have been available at the time the Statement would have been made.

We varied the order of Business, and it was made earlier than Questions. And so, the Minister was not available, and that the Minister would be coming to make the Statement. It is under this. The reason I said you are out of order is that I have already done what you are doing, and I drew his attention before the Majority Leader got up to say, yes, he is coming to make a Statement as a Minister, not as a Member of Parliament. So, I permitted him to do so, guided by the Standing Order 91(2). Please, you are my very good Friend, sometimes you are caught up by the pressure from behind you.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I remain your very good Friend. You have taught us in this House the need for all of us to aspire to learn. I was asking a question for clarity. You are speaking to me, not to him.

The Speaker: It is not the time for Questions and answers, and that is why I say you are out of order.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I am guided.

The Speaker: If it is Questions, we have to admit them and the answers would have to come depending on whether it is Oral or written. The rules are clear on that. Then we can allow you to go on.

Minister, please make your Statement.

Stampede at El-Wak Military Sports Facility

Acting Minister for Defence (Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson) (MP): Mr Speaker, I come before you today to inform the House of a tragic incident that occurred this morning, Wednesday, 12th November, 2025, at the El-Wak Military Sports Facility during the ongoing recruitment exercise of the Ghana Armed Forces.

Mr Speaker, the Ghana Armed Forces announced recruitment and enlistment processes about a month ago. The application process closed last Friday, 7th November, 2025. All potential applicants were duly notified to appear at their chosen regional recruitment centres for documentation verification today. This was for them to go through body selection.

Mr Speaker, this year's recruitment exercise is being conducted simultaneously across all regions. Indeed, it was a system designed to decentralise the process, reduce congestion, and ensure fairness, as well as to ensure accessibility nationwide.

Unfortunately, despite these measures, a stampede occurred at the El-Wak

facility in Accra. I regret to report that there were 34 persons who were direct casualties. Some of whom are not potential recruits, and others, unfortunately are not related to the recruitment at all.

Mr Speaker, out of these 34 casualties, six persons have been confirmed dead, five persons are in a critical condition, and as we speak they are at the Intensive Care Unit (ICU). Mr Speaker, 12 persons are fairly critical, and the rest are stable and under observation. Additionally, there is a reported case of one person hospitalised at the Kumasi recruitment centre, though that incident is unrelated to the stampede in Accra.

4:18 p.m.

Mr Speaker, in light of these developments, the Ministry of Defence has halted the recruitment process in Accra until further notice. I wish to assure Hon Members that in all other regions; the exercise is progressing smoothly and without incident.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry deeply mourns the loss of lives and extends condolences to the affected families. We are working closely with the Ghana Armed Forces, medical teams and law enforcement agencies to provide full support to the injured and to investigate the circumstances that led to this tragedy.

Mr Speaker, as a result, the Ghana Armed Forces has instituted an internal Board of Inquiry to investigate the cause of this unfortunate incident. The safety and dignity of applicants remain

paramount and the Ministry will take every necessary step to prevent a reoccurrence.

Mr Speaker, I so submit.

The Speaker: Hon Members, we would continue with the comments. I had earlier recognised Mr Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah, so he would be the first to speak.

Mr Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah (NPP — Takoradi): Mr Speaker, first and foremost, I would like to express my sympathies to the bereaved families and also to the Ghana Armed Forces for such an event.

Mr Speaker, I believe that a lot of us have spoken on this matter and it is time that our planning processes change for the recruitment of our young men into the Ghana Armed Forces. This is not the first time we have heard of stampedes during recruitments and this one is the turning point.

Mr Speaker, I believe that, like the Hon Member for Pusiga said, it is time that we decentralise all the way to the constituencies. This business of registration all anew, all the time, should also stop. I believe that when people get into the system and they are qualified, we should have a gradual process of recruiting them over time.

There is no point putting over 10,000 people or 5,000 people at just one point. There is no point. We can do it over a week and do say 1,000 at a time. Because when you put so many people together,

even the potential for disease transmission is also very high. So even though we are there to actually recruit people, we would actually be transmitting diseases to other persons.

I believe that it is time we go back to the drawing board, re-look at the whole system and make sure that the recruitment we are doing into the Ghana Armed Forces does not look or seem as if we are punishing our young people. I mean, why is it that people want to serve in the Ghana Armed Forces or the Ghana Police or others be put under pressure? They are young people. We should let them know that they have a duty to serve this country and when they want to serve, we should not punish them.

Mr Speaker, this also goes further to the issue about decent jobs for our young people. If over 30,000 people are trying to get into the Ghana Armed Forces, which might have just about 4,000 or 3,000 spaces per time and per year, then it shows that there is a critical need to address the issue of employment.

Mr Speaker, I have looked at the statistics before. If you take the number of young people that go to school and end up in government positions, it is just about 5 per cent. Clearly, we should know that the plan “A” that Ghanaians should be looking at consistently, should be about the private sector and entrepreneurship. Unfortunately, we tend to be educating our young people when they get to universities and then we start telling them to start looking to do something for themselves.

I believe that it is time that we start educating them right from primary school, so that by the time they get into senior high school, they are accustomed to the idea of doing something for themselves. Because the Government of Ghana (GoG) can never employ everybody under the system.

Mr Speaker, I know that during the last election, the NDC, for instance, promised 24-Hour Economy, thus one job, three shifts and three people. So, people were looking up to the opportunity of getting employment. The NPP at that time also promised four million jobs for the people—
[*Interruption*]

The Speaker: Make sure you do not generate debate, because where you are going—

Mr Darko-Mensah: Mr Speaker, I am not debating or generating debate. I was talking about decent jobs—
[*Interruption*]

The Speaker: Hon Member, you have to listen to me in silence.

Mr Darko-Mensah: Yes, please.

The Speaker: I am just drawing your attention not to go beyond the line to raise issues that will generate debate. It is a very simple guidance. You may go on.

Mr Darko-Mensah: Mr Speaker, thank for the guidance.

Mr Speaker, the issue of decent jobs are issues that we need to address. Naturally, there might be alternative views and alternative positions to that matter. But I want to draw the attention of the House to the fact that, we need to sit down and work together and agree that if we are working with, say, 24-Hour Economy or the four million jobs position of the NPP, how can we sit down and ask where we would draw the lines and where we would have to fix, so that we can give opportunities to our young people to work. Because, when more young people work, it increases the productivity of this country, generates jobs and it creates prosperity for all Ghanaians. When money moves around, wealth is generated.

We should find new ways of making sure that every young person is occupied. Because if we do not get them occupied and they always end up looking at one side which is towards the Military, Police and others where there are no jobs, these stampedes will continue to be problematic for us.

We know that the recruitment into the Ghana Armed Forces or the Ghana Police Service have always generated a lot of debate, even in this House. Sometimes we talk about political recruitment, people think that the protocol they need to get, they have not gotten it. Somebody at the Constituency thinks that this person has gone and they have not and no military person has actually been recruited in their House. It creates a lot of frustration for young people in this country.

I believe that since we are seeing this as a turning point, I would like to request the President to take the bull by the horns since he is the Commander-in-Chief of the Armed Forces. In the same way he has taken matters and stopped the work, he should also take responsibility for what has happened today and make sure that it does not happen again in this country.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I support the Makers of the Statements for this wonderful position and we extend our sympathies to the families.

The Speaker: Please, the health dimension.

Dr Nana Ayew Afriye (NPP — Effiduase/Asokore): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

I rise to comment on this Statement. First of all, I would want to congratulate the Makers of these Statements and also to extend my heartfelt sympathies to the families involved. It is a very painful one and I ask that we depoliticise this situation as much as possible. I am extremely disappointed in the Ghana Armed Forces. I think they failed in their risk assessment.

Mr Speaker, you can choose to let people go, but when it comes to the security agencies, I do not think that we can let them go off risk assessment. They would have to let us know the implications and what they did before. There is a search, especially after elections—therefore, what were they

anticipating and what measures did they put in place?

I am also happy to hear that the other regions are going on very well. Therefore, it means that, we should know the way forward with regard to these issues of screening. Now, I think that the Ghana Armed Forces also failed to do what we call a public health need assessment for what they were going to do. I doubt if the Ministry of Health or for that matter the Ghana Health Service, have anything to do with this. Because you are going on a course that borders on public health issues. I doubt if they have some sort of partnership with them.

Mr Speaker, again, in the House, when it comes to the Budget, your Committee clearly does not have the power to access the quasi hospitals and the health institutions under these agencies. Very often than not, the Health Committee has a mandate to take care of all health institutions. But because these are quasi hospitals, today if you ask for a briefing on the situation of the health status of those who are admitted, it will have to come from the Minister for Defence, who is not so strong at the issues of health.

Mr Speaker, I think your Committee must be able to update you on this issue. Then again, maybe the President, who is the Commander-in-Chief, may have to appoint a substantive Minister of Defence.

4:28 p.m.

Yes, our very good Friend, Hon Cassiel Ato Forson, is the acting Minister for Defence and the substantive Minister for Finance. But we cannot have one Ministry, having casualties at the start of the year, and then also along the way—It is one too much for everybody.

Probably, this is the best time for the Commander-in-Chief to appoint a Minister for Defence. I humbly submit to the Acting Minister for Defence that maybe in the compensation measure, we may want to graciously look at the families involved. There is nothing that we can do to appease them, but there is a way to get families to have a sense of belonging of Government being there for those who died and those who sustained injuries. If there is a way that we can see them through and let the family have some sort of replacement, the good people of this country will be extremely grateful.

Mr Speaker, I would be very happy if the Acting Minister for Defence will let us know what sort of measures are in place in the other regions going forward, that should any of these happen at those places, that there is hope for the end.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Peter Lanchene Toobu?

Supt. Rtd Peter Lanchene Toobu (NDC — Wa West): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to add some comments to the Statement ably made by my three Hon Colleagues, the Acting Minister for Defence, Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson, Hon Edem Agbana and Hon Frank Annoh-Dompreh.

Mr Speaker, I also want to thank the Majority Leader and Leader of Government Business for agreeing to vary the Business of the day to incorporate this very important Statement from the other Side of the House. That demonstrates good Leadership. It brings our democracy to another level, and it shows how important we are taking this issue that happened at the El-Wak Sports Stadium in this House.

Mr Speaker, I want to plead that let the optics be right. Let Ghanaians out there see that we are mourning, and all of us are sad in our hearts. I was so sad when the heckling was gradually becoming noisy and I thank you for bringing us back on track. We are mourning, and we should demonstrate to Ghanaians that we are very sad, and this should never happen again.

Mr Speaker, let me convey my condolences to the bereaved families. Lives so young and lost too quickly. It is very sad. As at 9:00 p.m. last night, people were at the El-Wak Sports Stadium, hoping and praying that this morning they would be attended to, and

their dream is to wear the green uniform to serve mother Ghana. What happened is quite unfortunate.

Mr Speaker, changing crowd behaviour over the years is worth studying. In the year 1990, if we had 10,000 people who had gathered for recruitment, and there were other opportunities available, their behaviour would definitely be different from 2025, when we have over 22,000 people at a particular point who are so desperate and do not believe that if they do not get this opportunity, there is nothing anywhere for them. So, I am saying that we may blame everybody and ourselves for what happened at the El-Wak Sports Stadium but the truth is that it has happened already. What are we learning from this incident? What can we learn? Decentralisation for recruitment is very good, but if we look at the history, the Police Service have a better record. The last time the Police Service recruited, if one goes to the Police Training School, over 4,000 people were handled in a day. How did it happen? At 6:00 a.m., 500 people were invited. At 8:00 a.m. in the morning, another 500. Within a two-hour interval, people were invited in groups. Gradually, 2,000 people were dealt with in a day without overcrowding.

Mr Speaker, these are all best practises that we need to learn and with the inclusion of technology, I am quite sure this is not a very difficult thing to do. We are all surprised that the crowd surged and became very violent to the point that

they lost control, and we lost these six people.

Mr Speaker, I want to plead, and I thank the Acting Minister for Defence for halting the process in Accra. Let us caution all other commanders in the other recruitment centres, that they should learn from what happened in Accra and ensure that the exercise becomes successful across the country. Although we have halted the process in Accra, we appreciate it and we support the move, and gradually, we will learn from best practices and this recruitment exercise will still be very smooth. The numbers that are coming in the other security sectors should not threaten us, because this is the best practice that we are learning, and I am sure that when the Police, Immigration, Fire and Prisons Services begin recruitment, we will not see anything of this nature.

Mr Speaker, with these few comments, I want to thank you for the opportunity.

The Speaker: Hon Members, I had to permit the Minister for Finance to go and complete the finishing touches for the Budget Statement for tomorrow. So, if you saw him leave, he has left with my permission. I will take one more, and then we can proceed to do other Business.

Yes, Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh?

Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh (NPP — Bosome Freho): Mr Speaker, thank you very much, I rise to comment on this Statement as a young Ghanaian. As a young man who sees the challenges that confront this country, I would say that the country is sitting on tenterhooks.

Mr Speaker, I want to join in proffering some solutions to the challenges that are bedevilling us. These young Ghanaians left their various houses with some dreams, the dream of serving their nation but this dream ended up taking their lives. Their hopes were lost and their dreams were shattered. This is as a result of some recruitment failures that successive governments, not just one government have looked upon from time immemorial.

Mr Speaker, Members will be surprised how the only thing most young men look forward to, as soon as they complete senior high school, is to join the Ghana Armed Forces, the Police Service, National Fire Service or Immigration. This is as a result of security of jobs and the unavailability of jobs that is facing the young people of this country. It will surprise one to know that year in, year out, about 20,000 Ghanaians buy forms only for the Services to recruit less than 3,000, about 5 or 10 per cent of these Ghanaians. Yet they queue in their numbers and go through frustration all in the name of serving their country.

Mr Speaker, it is time that we look at our processes. We must, as a country, begin to look at a comprehensive digitisation system that will help us recruit our young men without allowing them to go and queue every year like we see. Some of these processes can be digitised so that we will reduce the hardship, the burden and frustration that our young people go through. We must also look at how opportunities are distributed for our good people in this country.

Mr Speaker, we may all shy away from the truth but even out of the 20,000 people that are queuing there, the Services are taking less than 3,000 or 4,000 – I may be wrong with the figures but even inherent in those figures, there are opportunities that are given to some Ghanaians and some Ghanaians are also not having some of these opportunities.

4:38 p.m.

Mr Speaker, that is how we must look at this situation; how we will distribute opportunities equitable to every Ghanaian in this country. One of the makers Statement, my good Friend, Mr Edem Agbana, called for accountability. I am not just looking at accountability. I am looking at the overhaul opportunities that we manage in this country. Let us look at an overhaul system so that we may not—Because we have seen some of these processes, and the sad part of this is that all the people that are confirmed dead are females. These are young

Ghanaian women who wanted to serve, and we are today mourning the loss of these innocent souls. I do not know how the families will be compensated because their family members who were going out there to give them hope ended up losing their hopes.

Mr Speaker, I will crave your indulgence and beg that we apply some tactfulness and deep thinking in how we recruit, give opportunities to our young people in this country, and how the system will be managed without repeating some of this chaos we repeat every successive year when we are recruiting. So that in future, our young people would want to serve with pride and dignity, without losing their lives, or without ending these dreams and hopes that they have.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I want to commend the makers of the Statements for the urgent timing that they brought the Statement; Mr Frank Annor-Dompreh, and my good Friend, Mr Edem Agbana, and the Hon Minister as well, for swiftly responding to this matter.

The Speaker: Hon Members, you all know that this is one of the most respected institutions of state, and the leaders and personnel of the Ministry of Defence have constantly been rated above Parliamentarians when it comes to trust of the people. So, this is an institution that we revere, and in fact, my own story shows that, because of my

reverence and the commitment to serve, in 1977, I went there for enlistment, not recruitment.

Hon Members, please, may I have your ears?

I went there for an enlistment. At that time, we were not looking for employment. We were going to serve as men. There were no women in the military. They were all men. And it was so smooth at that time. I was deselected.
[Laughter]

Yes, and they told me why I was deselected before I proceeded to the University. So, this is an opportunity for us to rethink about the whole process of enlistment, recruitment and employment in the public service. We have a serious challenge, and we have to confront it head on. As a result of that, even when I was offered the opportunity to be the Minister for Defence, I declined that offer. His Excellency, the current President, was present when I was offered the position. At the time, he was the Vice-President. I declined, for good reason.

So, please, this is an institution that we all revere. It is because of them that we are all protected. You know what they do. They decide not to sleep like the Police, so that we can sleep; it is not an easy job.

So, please, even though some measures have been taken, I will direct

our Committee to follow up on the process, and also, emphasise on what others have said, for us to expedite the process of appointing a substantive Minister. It is not because the current acting Minister is not capable, but we know the pressures on him. We need to have somebody who will come with a full report and look at some of the issues you have raised. What prevents this country from having a continuous recruitment or enlistment process? We do not have to wait and do it once every year, or sometimes two years, so that you can accumulate so many people, and they have to rush to try and get recognition and end up not living. So, please, with your support, the Committee on Defence and Interior, kindly follow up on this matter.

Later, the Leaders can programme and schedule a date for us to get the Committee and the Minister to give us a full brief on it, and we will share information, because it is something that has already been debated by civil society, and there are a lot of proposals. They will give us the reasons those proposals cannot be implemented, and we can all work together and find a solution to this problem. If not, the future may even be more terrifying than what we have experienced today.

So, I would want to, on behalf of the House, humbly convey the deepest condolences to the parents and families of the deceased. The House prays for the speedy healing and recovery of the

injured. We also sympathise with the Ministry of Defence and call on the leadership to have cool hearts to handle this matter. We sincerely thank the health personnel, together with the Ambulance Service and all those who have rushed to at least, attend to the injured and the deceased.

Please, I want Leadership to accompany me so that we can visit the injured. I am told they are at the 37 Military Hospital, so that the House will go and see what the situation is, and together, we may discuss later what to do next. With this, I want to call on you for us to stand at least in a minute's silence for the souls of our departed patriots.

[A minute silence was observed]

4:48 p.m.

The Speaker: Hon Members, may the souls of these young patriotic sons and daughters and those of all the faithful departed rest in perfect peace. Amen.

Yes, Hon Majority Leader, I wanted to vary the order of Business again and to let us take some items before I lead the Leadership to the hospital while the First Deputy Speaker takes the Chair and continues with the rest. But there is a Paper that he wants to present, so I want to grant him that opportunity.

Yes, Hon Majority Leader, you are on your feet.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I do not know if your plan to vary the order of

Business is for us to take what I am hoping we would, which is on the *Order Paper Addendum*. I want to lay the Report of the Appointments Committee on the nomination of Justice Paul Baffoe-Bonnie, which is the item numbered 1 on the *Order Paper Addendum*.

The Speaker: Yes, Minority Frontbench?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, we had a meeting and the understanding was that the Paper be laid today so that we take the Report tomorrow. So, to the extent that, that is being pursued, I am not opposed to same.

The Speaker: Well, I was not part of the discussion, but I thought tomorrow would be too busy and if you are minded, this is a serious matter too. You could take it on Friday, not tomorrow. Why do you want to take it tomorrow?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I do not mind taking it on Friday.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we have discussed among ourselves and have agreed that we should take it tomorrow. This Side is ready to take it tomorrow, so, I urge you, Mr Speaker, to allow us to take it tomorrow.

The Speaker: Hon Members, then we may need to vary the commencement of Sitting tomorrow, because if we are to start Sitting at 2:00 p.m., the Budget Statement alone could take not less than two hours, some take more than that. If

you want us to start in the morning, at what time, 11:00 a.m. or 12:00 noon? It depends on how long you want to— You prefer 12:00 noon?

Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think 12:00 noon would do.

The Speaker: Is that a consensus?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: I think Leadership should further engage on this matter because there was an earlier communication which has also informed the scheduling of other meetings of various Caucuses. We, for instance, have scheduled a meeting at 11:00 a.m. when we got a prior notification that tomorrow's presentation will start at 2:00 p.m. I am also aware the Business Committee has been scheduled to meet tomorrow at midday. So, if the Hon Majority Leader is aware of this, we should take that into consideration because that communication came out earlier that the presentation would be at 2:00 p.m. But he cannot decide on his own. He has to consult us.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, if it works for us, we can shift the Business Committee meeting to an earlier time. We always engaged to agree on the time for Business Committee sitting. The Clerk consults us, and because we are a smaller number, it is easier to shift it to an earlier time. So, Mr Speaker, we will take the Report of the Appointments Committee on the nomination and the Budget Statement tomorrow.

The Speaker: Hon Members, the understanding is that at 12:00 noon, we will take the Motion for which the Paper is about to be laid, and then at 2:00 p.m., we will take the Budget Statement. Leadership will discuss and fix the rest of the items for tomorrow.

Yes, Hon First Deputy Minority Whip?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I think that matter is settled.

Mr Speaker, you indicated that you might leave us to 37 Military Hospital, and I want to draw your attention to the Motion numbered 14 on today's *Order Paper*, and humbly request, if it will please you, that you still occupy the Chair for that Motion to be taken.

The Speaker: You are referring to the Motion numbered 14?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Yes, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: What is the pleasure of the House? I can come back from the visit and preside to take that Motion later in the day.

Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think we should rush to the hospital to check on the injured and then come back and take the Motion. If that is the case, we may have to take a short suspension of Sitting so that—

The Speaker: Well, I do not need to go with all Leaders. I think that we need representation so that Business can continue while I lead the delegation to the hospital.

Mr Ayariga: Then we can just take the item on the *Order Paper Addendum* now and then after that—

The Speaker: Hon Members, I direct we vary the order of Business. At the Commencement of Public Business, item 1, Presentation of Papers.

The following Papers to be presented by the Chairman of the Committee.

4:58 p.m.

PAPER

By the Chairman of the Committee—

Seventeenth Report of the Appointments Committee on His Excellency the President's nomination of Justice Paul Baffoe-Bonnie for appointment as Chief Justice of the Republic of Ghana.

The Speaker: I now call on the First Deputy Speaker to take the Chair. Leaders, get ready for us to move to the 37 Military Hospital. I have drawn the attention of the First Deputy Speaker to the items to handle. We did that at Conclave, and that is what he will be handling until I return.

I only say Leadership will go with us, not everybody, and in this case, it will be the Majority Leader, Minority Leader, Chief Whips, and my good self. I think that should be sufficient. We do not need a large team to go there. The Clerk may join us because he is the boss of the Service, so he should represent the Service. I am told that the gender is not represented, and so I will hazard an opinion that we add two Hon ladies, one from each Side of the House, in spite of the numbers.

Who are the seniors? I can identify a lot of seniors. Now, which of the seniors? I cannot see Abena. Well, I leave that to the Leaders. Please decide on the ladies so that we can go with them too.

5:02 p.m. — [HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER, MR BERNARD AHIAFOR, IN THE CHAIR]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Deputy Majority Leader, do we go back to the item numbered 6?

Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, we are looking at the item numbered 6 —Questions. The Minister is here, and we want him to answer the Questions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Minister for Roads and Highways is scheduled to respond to some Questions. He has been sitting for some time. May I humbly ask him to take the designated seat?

Hon Members, the Minister is seated and we have the first Question which stands in the name of Hon Member for Akan, Hon Yao Gomado. You have the floor.

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, I stand on Order 88(3) with the prior authorization of the Member concerned to seek your leave in order to ask the Question advertised.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please do.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF ROADS AND HIGHWAYS

Plans to Construct a Bridge over the River Asokorkor

Mr Frank Afriyie on behalf of Mr Yao Gomado (NDC—Akan): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways whether the Ministry has plans to construct a bridge over River Asokorkor to serve Dodo-Bethel and Dodo-Amanfrom.

Minister for Roads and Highways (Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity.

Background

River Asokorkor in the Kadjebi District of the Oti region has a span of over 70m. Dodo-Bethel and Dodo-Amanfrom are among a number of communities separated by the Asokorkor River

Current Programme

There is no contract for the construction of the Asokorkor Bridge.

Future Programme

Detailed engineering design and geotechnical studies to determine an appropriate crossing point have been carried out, and cost estimates have been submitted for consideration in the 2026 Budget upon the availability of funds.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Afriyie: No, Mr Speaker, except to ask the Minister to expedite processes to have the bridge constructed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Member.

Hon Members, we move to Question numbered 474, which stands in the name of Kwabena Boateng, Member of Parliament for Ejisu. You have the floor.

Current State of Roads in the Ejisu Constituency

Mr Kwabena Boateng (NPP—Ejisu): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways about the current state of the Kokobra – Okyerekrom – Ekyem – Achiase road in

the Ejisu Constituency and when work will resume to complete the road.

Thank you.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker,

Background

The Kokobra – Okyerekrom – Ekyem – Achiase Road is a connector road located within the Ashanti Region serving communities in the Ejisu Municipal and Bosomtwe District areas.

Current Programme

The road was awarded under the contract titled “Rehabilitation of Abirem - Antoa -Bonwire Road (km 0-10.38) and Critical Access roads (Kokobra – Okyerekrom – Ekyem – Achiase 17.3km)” for execution and completion in Twenty-Four (24) Calendar Months. The project commenced on 28th June 2024, for completion by 27th June 2026. The progress of work is currently at 49.3 per cent physical completion.

The Contractor is currently not on site due to a delay in payment for work done. Efforts are being made to get the Contractor back to the site to complete all outstanding works.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary question?

Mr K. Boateng: Mr Speaker, respectfully, yes.

Mr Speaker, may I know the name of the contractor with respect to the road in Ejisu?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, the name of the contractor is Kofi Job.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further questions?

Mr K. Boateng: Mr Speaker, there will be none except to reiterate the plight of the people to the Minister for a timely intervention. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Hon Members, this is a constituency-specific Question. We move to Question numbered 383, which stands in the name of Samuel Awuku, Member of Parliament for Akuapem North.

Completion of the Road from Larteh Junction to Larteh Township

Mr Samuel Awuku (NPP—Akuapem North): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the road from Larteh Junction to Larteh Township will be completed, as well as the inner roads in the township.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker,

Background

5:08 p.m.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, the Larteh Junction – Larteh Township Road is a key route located in the Eastern Region, connecting the Larteh community to the main Mamfe–Koforidua Road (N4).

Current Programme

The road was awarded under the contract titled “Rehabilitation of Mamfe (Larteh Junction) – Larteh Road (6.20km) and Access Roads (2.35km) and Larteh Town Roads (5.10km); Total Length = 13.65km” for execution and completion in Twenty-Four (24) Calendar Months. The project commenced on 5th November, 2024 for completion by 4th November, 2026. The progress of work is currently at 45.0 per cent physical completion. The Contractor suspended works due to delay in payment for work done but has indicated his willingness to remobilise to site by December, 2025. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any follow-up question?

Mr Awuku: Mr Speaker, that would be all.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. We move to the Question numbered 257, standing in the name of Mr Maxwell Lukutor.

Ing Surv Maxwell Kwame Lukutor (NDC — South Tongu): Mr Speaker, I rise on Order 90 (2) which says where a Question is admitted, a Member may withdraw that question by leave of the Speaker, so I seek your leave to withdraw the Question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, leave is hereby granted, accordingly the Question is withdrawn.

The Question numbered 287, standing in the name of Mr Appiah Kwame Kodua, Member of Parliament for Fanteakwa North. Hon Member, you have the floor.

Continuation of the Begoro Township Road

Mr Kwame Appiah Kodua (NPP — Fanteakwa North): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the Begoro township roads will continue after the contractor left the site.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, Begoro is the capital of Fanteakwa North District in the Eastern Region.

Current Programme

The town roads were awarded under the contract titled “Reconstruction of Mpraeso - Hweehwee - Oyimso Road (47km) and Upgrading of Begoro - Feyiase Road (Km 1.0 - 20.1)” for execution and completion in forty-two

(42) Calendar Months. The progress of work is currently at 68 per cent physical completion. The Contractor is currently on site and actively working on the Mpraeso -Hweehwee – Oyimso section.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Kodua: Mr Speaker, rightly so. With respect, the contract title mentioned by the Hon Minister is not the Begoro township road. I think I have done some work about the road. The Begoro township road is different from the contract title of roads the Hon Minister mentioned, to the best of my knowledge. I have done some work on that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Minister?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, what I read was that the reconstruction of Mpraeso - Hweehwee then Oyimso Road (47km) and Upgrading of Begoro - Feyiase Road (Km 1.0 - 20.1). It is a combination of project lumped as a project. What I am saying is that the contractor is working on one section of the road currently and not the township roads you are talking about. He is working within the same contract, but not in the town you are referring to. But the township roads are part of the same contract.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further question?

Mr Kodua: Rightly so, Mr Speaker. The Begoro township roads has stalled. I want to find out from the Hon Minister what the Ministry is doing to ensure that the contractor of the township road will return to site? Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, by our records, this project is one of the projects under the Cocoa Roads, and the contract sum is in excess of US\$77 million. Obviously, the contractor has done significant amount of work and has not been paid. As you may be aware, Government has taken a decision that says that Cocobod will no longer indulge in award and supervision of Cocoa roads. That official statement will be made, so these projects are now being rationalised under highways or feeder roads so that we can appropriately fund them. That is what the reason is.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Kodua: Mr Speaker, I want to thank the Minister for Roads and Highways for the highlights. We are grateful.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh — *rose* —

Mr Davis Ansah Opoku — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you. Hon Members, this is a constituency specific Question.

Hon Members, we are supposed to take about 10 Statements today. Two has been taken; we are left with eight, but the pleasure is yours.

Yes?

Mr Davis Ansah Opoku: Mr Speaker, just to acknowledge that these roads are in my constituency. The challenge is that with the 68 per cent physical completion, I can say that the contractor has done significant work. Currently, the contractor is not on site, and it is a matter that I wanted to bring to your attention. We may probably revisit to find out why he has refused to come on site. However, I admit that talking with him, he mentioned issues of payment. Probably, even the Minister could—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, this is not a supplementary question.

The Question numbered 400, standing in the name of Hon Daniel Dung Mahama, MP for Talensi.

Contstruction of Roads in the Talensi Consituency

Mr Daniel Dung Mahama (NDC — Talensi): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the following roads in the Talensi Constituency will be constructed: (i) Tongo through Yameriga, Sheaga Duuei linking Nabdam District (ii) Tongo through Baare, Tongo Beo linking Bolgatanga East District.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker,

Background

- (i) The Tongo through Yameriga, Sheaga Duuei road linking Nabdam District forms part of the regional road (R158) which is from Wikongo to Nangode.

Current Programme

There is no programme on the road.

Future Programme

Engineering design studies and cost estimates have been carried out on the road and submitted for consideration under the 2026 Budget upon the availability of funds.

- (ii) Tongo through Baare, Tongo Beo linking Bolgatanga East District Road

Background

The Tongo through Baare, Tongo Beo road linking Bolgatanga East District feeder road is captured in the Department of Feeder Roads (DFR) database as Tongo-Baare-Zuarungu feeder road, which is 10.0km long. It is an inter-district road connecting Talensi and Bolgatanga East Districts of the Upper East Region. It is an engineered gravel road in fair surface condition.

Current Programme

There is no programme on the road.

Future Programme

Engineering studies and cost estimates will be carried out on the road for consideration under the 2026 Budget upon the availability of funds.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr D. D. Mahama: Mr Speaker, I thank the Minister for his quick response. I am so grateful.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Question numbered 452, standing in the name of Mr Ralph Poku-Adusei, MP for Bekwai.

Rehabilitation of Kensere-Pampaso and Dotom-Koniyaw Roads

Mr Ralph Poku-Adusei (NPP—Bekwai): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways what steps the Ministry is taking to ensure permanent rehabilitation of the Kensere-Pampaso and Dotom-Koniyaw roads in Bekwai Constituency.

5:18 p.m.

The overall progress of works is estimated at 31 per cent physical completion. The contractor is currently not on site and works have stalled due to delay in payment for work done. Efforts

are being made to get the contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

Dotom-Koniyaw Road

Background

The Dotom-Koniyaw Feeder Road is 7.0km long. It is located in the Bekwai Municipality of the Ashanti Region. It is an engineered gravel road in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

The Dotom-Koniyaw Feeder Road was awarded under the contract titled “Upgrading of Dotom-Koniyaw Feeder Road (7.0km)”. The contract commenced on 18th May, 2021 for completion by 17th May, 2022. The overall progress of works is estimated at 19 per cent physical completion. The contractor is currently not on site and works have stalled due to delay in payment for work done. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

Mr Poku-Adusei: Mr Speaker, in the Answer given by the Hon Minister, clearly in both cases, the work has stalled due to delay in payment for work done. So, the situation in the constituency is quite dire. I want to find out from the Hon Minister if there are any timelines set by the Ministry for the contractors to receive payments so that they can return to the site.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, I sympathise with my Hon Colleague

regarding the nature of road in his constituency. The reason for the delay in payment is simply because, once again, this was also awarded under the Ghana Cocoa Board (COCOBOD). It is clearly a case of COCOBOD awarding projects far and beyond what they are capable of funding sustainably. Obviously, as Members of Parliament, we know that the Cocoa Road Programme has collapsed because they cannot raise enough money even to buy cocoa beans, let alone pay for the works they have awarded. That is why Government have taken the decision to rationalise this. So, in due course, all this will be realigned and a more sustainable source of funding identified for the contractors to go back to site and complete the works. Thank you.

Mr Poku-Adusei: I want to find out from the Hon Minister if he can assist the House with the contract sum in these two contracts. This is because I am reliably informed that mobilisation was paid in both cases—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, file a specific Question if you want to know the contract sum.

Mr Poku-Adusei: Yes, Mr Speaker, the question I want to ask is if the Hon Minister can help the House with the contract sum in these two contracts.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: File a specific Question—The Hon Minister indicated that he has the answer? —Your question is “to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways what steps the Ministry is taking to ensure permanent rehabilitation

of the Kensere-Pampaso ...” and you mentioned the roads. Based on your Question, the Minister will prepare an Answer to give. So, in a situation where this is the Question and you are now asking the Hon Minister to give you the contract sum, it offends the Rules.

Mr Poku-Adusei: Mr Speaker, if I may, in the answer given by the Hon Minister —

Mr Annoh-Dompreh — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, if I may, Order 89 is clear and our Hon Member prefaced his question by asking the Minister if he “may”. Mr Speaker, yes, the Hon Minister did not speak into the microphone, but the he is clearly willing and it is reasonable that his follow-up question is flowing from the answers of the Hon Minister. So, Mr Speaker, may I appeal to you, especially where the Hon Minister has the answers readily available, if he is minded to answer that question?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, our Rules are not at the will of the Hon Minister. The Rules are very clear. Do you have any further question?

Mr Poku-Adusei: I have another question for the Hon Minister. Mr Speaker, in the Answer given by the Hon Minister, clearly the issue of delays in payments is quite prominent. So, I want to find out from him whether there are any mechanisms or plans being put in

place to avoid any future delays in payment so that delays in road construction can be avoided in future.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, indeed the question by my Hon Colleague is well placed. The easiest way to avoid contractors being given contracts and they work and are not being paid is if we limit and assure ourselves that we will only award contracts when we can fund them. But unfortunately, Mr Speaker, including myself, when Members of Parliament are under pressure to intervene in the nature of roads in their constituencies, we all forget that when we pass the Budget, there is only a certain amount of money in the Budget. We keep asking that contracts are awarded irrespective of what the state can fund. So, it is easy to say yes, Government will be prudent in paying contractors, but the reality is how much did we approve in the Budget for the payment of contractors in any fiscal year? One would see a vast difference between what has been approved and what we have committed to in terms of roads.

In the last Budget, maybe the CAPEX of the Ministry is around GHC2.53 billion, but the commitment of the Ministry is over GHC101 billion. That does not even include works done which have not been paid for, which is approaching GHC30 billion. So, really, we are prudent in making sure we only award what we can fund and that would have been the solution. But I know it is easier said than done.

Mr Poku-Adusei: Mr Speaker, I want to thank the Hon Minister for the answers given. I am satisfied.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We move to the Question numbered 473, standing in the name of Mr Alamzy Nikyema Billa, MP for Chiana-Paga.

Mr Nikyema Billa: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the hard-working, competent, and intelligent Minister for Roads and Highways —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, all that you have said is not part of the Question. *[Laughter]* You are called upon to ask the Question as captured in the *Order Paper*.

Mr Nikyema Billa: Mr Speaker, I am trying to impress the Hon Minister so that he could fix my roads.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Will you ask the Question or not?

Fixing of the Collapsed Bridge on the Mavio-Manyoro Road

Mr Alamzy Nikyema Billa (NDC — Chiana-Paga): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the collapsed bridge on the Mavio-Manyoro road will be fixed.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, indeed, I know this bridge. My simple response is that currently we do not have any active project on this.

Background

The collapsed bridge on the Mavio (Navio)-Manyoro Feeder Road was a 36m span steel bridge. It was constructed under Ghana-Dutch Bridges Programme.

Current Programme

There is no contract for the construction of the bridge.

Future Programme

Detailed engineering design and geotechnical studies to determine an appropriate crossing point has been carried out and cost estimates submitted for consideration in the 2026 Budget upon the availability of funds.

But, Mr Speaker, we have programmed this bridge for an intervention and shortly, my Colleague would be happy to hear that we would be working on this. The Navio Bridge is a very critical bridge in the country. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, do you have any supplementary question.

Mr Nikyema Billa: Mr Speaker, on this particular Question, I do not have a supplementary question. I wish to thank the Minister very well.

5:28 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Question numbered 477 also stands in the name of Mr Alamzy Nikyema Billa, Member of Parliament for Chiana-Paga. You have the floor.

Resumption and Completion of Works on the Chuchuliga–Chiana Road

Mr Alamzy Nikyema Billa (NDC — Chiana-Paga): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when work on the Chuchuliga-Chiana Road would resume and be completed.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker,

Background

Chuchuliga to Chiana Road is 11km long and forms part of the Navrongo - Chuchuliga – Chiana – Nakong – Sissili Road, which is a National Road (N13). The Chuchuliga – Chiana Road is bituminous surfaced and in poor condition.

Current Programme

The road has been captured under the Big Push Programme which is under procurement. Fortunately, it is part of the road that the President tasked us for yesterday. So very soon, the contractor would be back on site working.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Nikyema Billa: Mr Speaker, I do not have any other questions, but I wish to thank the Minister for Roads and Highways for giving us the assurance that they would soon start with our roads. Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Question time has ended. We have exhausted the Questions on the *Order Paper*. I want to thank the

Minister for Roads and Highways very much for attending upon the House to respond to the Questions scheduled for him.

Hon Minister, thank you very much. You are discharged. Hon Members, we move to item numbered 7. Though we have taken some Statements earlier, we have about eight Statements. I want to be guided by the Leadership as to the number of contributors we should take on each Statement.

Hon Members, we are doing so in order to give the opportunity to all the makers of the Statements.

Yes, Deputy Majority Leader?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, as you rightly said, we have 10 Statements, two of which have already been read. We have eight Statements left, which I think is quite a number. I would indulge you to admit two Statements on each Side.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leadership?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, we are not opposing. I think it is all right for us to proceed with that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. The ground rule is set.

The first Statement stands in the name of Ms Zuwera Mohammed Ibrahimah, Member of Parliament for Salaga South, and the second Statement stands in the name of Ms Damata Ama Appianimaa Salam, Member of Parliament for Afigya Kwabre South. These Statements are similar, and I plead with the House that we take these Statements jointly

I will therefore give the floor to Ms Zuwera Mohammed Ibrahimah to read the first Statement.

STATEMENTS

Honouring the Legacy of Her Excellency Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings

Ms Zuwera Mohammed Ibrahimah (NDC — Salaga South): Mr Speaker, I am grateful for the opportunity to make this Statement. I do not know whether it is by providence that this Statement is only being made today, after reliable information indicates that all six people who died at the El-Wak Stadium are females. If this information is true, that indeed is very heartbreaking.

I have pondered over the information since I got it. But Mr Speaker, the Statement I am going to read in memory of Her Excellency Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings, the former First Lady of the Republic of Ghana, speaks about nothing but her endeavours and her campaign to empower women.

Mr Speaker, inasmuch as this Statement is in her memory, I would dedicate it to the six females who we have just lost. May their souls rest in peace.

Mr Speaker and Hon Colleagues, I rise with a heavy heart, yet with profound gratitude, to pay tribute to a woman whose life embodied courage, vision, and an unwavering commitment to the empowerment of Ghana's women and children. Her Excellency Nana Konadu

Agyeman-Rawlings, Ghana's longest-serving First Lady, departed this life on Thursday, 23rd October, 2025, at the age of 76.

Mr Speaker, born on November 17, 1948, in Cape Coast to Felicia and J.O.T. Agyeman, Nana Konadu Agyeman was named after the revered Asante Queen, Nana Konadu Yiadom II, who ruled in the absence of the exiled Asantehene in 1896.

Mr Speaker, from the beginning, her name carried the weight of leadership and resilience. Her mother, an educator, forced by colonial law to abandon her teaching career upon marriage, ensured that young Konadu understood both the power of education and the injustice of systems that denied women their full potential. This early lesson would become the driving force of her life's work.

Mr Speaker, it was at Achimota School where she met the late Flight Lieutenant Jerry John Rawlings, beginning a partnership that would span nearly five decades and reshape Ghana's political and social landscape. Together, they raised four children: Dr Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlings, my dear Friend and Colleague and the Hon Member for Korley Klotey, Yaa Asantewa, Amina, and Kimathi. Each child is a testament to her devotion as a mother and her belief in nurturing the next generation of leaders.

5:38 p.m.

Mr Speaker, when Nana Konadu founded the 31st December Women's

Movement in 1982, she did not merely create an organisation, she ignited a revolution. At a time when Ghana's economy was in ruins and women's voices were systematically excluded from national development, She travelled the dusty roads of our most remote communities, sat with village chiefs, danced with townsfolk, and listened to the struggles of ordinary women. She understood instinctively what many failed to see, that without the effective mobilisation of women, Ghana's largest labour force, our nation could never achieve true economic transformation.

Mr Speaker, her vision was both radical and practical. The movement established over 870 daycare centres and preschools nationwide, liberating thousands of working mothers to pursue economic opportunities while ensuring their children received quality early education.

Mr Speaker, she championed microcredit facilities, literacy programmes and small-scale enterprises, from cassava processing plants to batik making, from beekeeping to sole production, creating pathways for women to achieve economic independence and recognition as equals.

Mr Speaker, through the Movement, she mobilised more than two million women across Ghana, transforming them from passive observers into active agents of change. She stood before traditional authorities and boldly addressed family planning and contraceptive use, defying social norms that had long kept women

silent. She fought against *Trokosi*, female genital mutilation and child marriage, practises that had subjugated generations of women.

Mr Speaker, Nana Konadu's influence extended far beyond the borders of Ghana. Her participation in the 1995 Fourth World Conference on Women in Beijing, profoundly shaped her advocacy. There, she witnessed China's commitment to gender equality in education and returned home with renewed determination. She declared and I quote, "African women must be present where power is exercised".

Mr Speaker, her advocacy helped secure the passage of the landmark 1989 Intestate Succession Law, the Intestate Succession Act, 1985 (PNDCL 111) protecting the inheritance rights of women, widows and children; a legislative triumph that rescued countless families from destitution. She influenced the incorporation of gender equality provisions into our 1992 Constitution.

Mr Speaker, her work contributed to policies on maternal and child health, agricultural support for women farmers, and the establishment of the National Commission on Women and Development. At the Beijing +5 Conference in New York, in the year 2000. She articulated her philosophy with characteristic clarity and I quote:

"...my desire is to see the emancipation of women at every level of development to enable them to contribute and benefit

from the socioeconomic and political progress of the country. Women's vital role of promoting peace in the family, the country, and the world at large must be acknowledged.”

Mr Speaker, she firmly believed that change began with one woman who says, “enough is enough, one family at a time and continues onwards from one generation to the other”.

Mr Speaker, Nana Konadu was never content to remain in anyone's shadows. In 2016, she shattered yet another glass ceiling by becoming the first woman to contest for the presidency of Ghana, a bold act that inspired generations of young women to envision themselves in positions of power. Though her National Democratic Party campaign did not succeed electorally, her candidacy itself was a victory for every girl child who dared to dream beyond prescribed boundaries.

Mr Speaker, she served as First Lady from 1979 and again from 1981 to 2001, spanning two decades of transformative change in our nation's history. She was elected the first vice chairperson of the NDC in 2009, demonstrating her political acumen and organisational prowess. Her 2018 memoir, I quote “*It Takes a Woman*”, chronicled her journey and philosophy, offering invaluable insights for future generations of activists and leaders.

Mr Speaker, as I stand here today, I think of my friend and Colleague, Dr Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlings, who

carries forward her mother's legacy in these very Halls. I think of the countless women across Ghana whose lives were fundamentally altered by Nana Konadu's intervention. The market women running thriving businesses, the children who attended these daycare centres, the new professionals, the widows who retained their property rights and the girls who were spared from harmful cultural practises.

But Mr Speaker, I also recognise that the work remains unfinished. Even as we honour her memory, we must acknowledge that by current projections, full gender equality will not be achieved until 2158. Five generations from now, Nana Konadu, noted this troubling statistic in one of her public statements this past March, urging us to, “accelerate action for gender equality”. Her legacy must be a memorial we visit occasionally, but a mandate we carry forward daily.

We in this House, particularly those of us privileged to serve on the Committee on Gender, Children and Social Welfare Committee, have a special responsibility. We must ensure that more women occupy spaces of influence in government, business, civil society and traditional leadership.

Mr Speaker, we must pass legislation that truly empowers women economically. We must invest in programmes that develop the next generation of female leaders. We must challenge every stereotype, call out every discrimination and question every bias that holds our daughters back.

Mr Speaker, Ghana has lost an irreplaceable champion. Africa has lost a pioneering advocate, but the flame she lit burns on in every woman who stands a little taller because of her work. In every child who dreams a little bigger because she proved it possible. In every policy that protects the vulnerable because she demanded it.

Mr Speaker, to Dr Zanetor, Yaa Asantewaa, Amina, and Kimathi, our hearts go out to you. Your mother was a national treasure who gave her life to the service of others. Her strength lives on in you.

In conclusion, I would quote the words of Nana Konadu, often used and here she says,

“Here is to strong women, may we know them, may we be them and may we raise them”.

Mr Speaker, may the soul of Her Excellency Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings, rest in perfect peace. May her legacy inspire us to complete the work she courageously began.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity— [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is now the turn of the Hon Member for Afigya Kwabre South, to also read her Statement.

Tribute to Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings

Ms Damata Ama Appianimaa Salam (NPP — Afigya Kwabre South): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I rise with deep sorrow to make a Statement on the passing of Ghana’s former First Lady, H.E. Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings, whose death has brought grief to our nation.

Mr Speaker, this loss is particularly personal to me and the good people of Afigya Kwabre South. The late Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings hailed from Mpobi, one of the proud and historic towns in my Constituency. She had a great working relationship with the Queen Mothers in the Constituency. Therefore, we mourn not only a national icon, but also a beloved daughter of our land whose life brought honour and recognition to the Constituents.

Mr Speaker, the late Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings was a woman of great courage, intellect and conviction. As the wife of the former President Jerry John Rawlings, she served Ghana with exceptional dignity and distinction. Her life was one of service to her family, country and especially to women and children across this nation. Through her visionary leadership of the 31st December Women’s Movement,

5:48 p.m.

She spearheaded programmes that transformed the lives of countless Ghanaian women by promoting education, entrepreneurship, and community development. Her commitment to gender equality and empowerment opened new pathways for women’s participation in national life.

Mr Speaker, in her hometown Mpobi, her love and commitment were felt in tangible ways. She championed the provision of health centres, educational facilities, access to electricity and water for the community; these are projects that continue to serve the people to this day. These interventions brought hope, improved livelihoods, and enhanced access to essential services, leaving an enduring mark on the lives of her people.

Mr Speaker, beyond her humanitarian works, the late Nana Konadu Agyemang Rawlings, who draws her royal lineage in Mpobi, stood tall as a bold political leader, principled, fearless, and deeply passionate about social justice and national progress. She inspired generations of Ghanaian women, including many of us who today have the privilege to serve in public office. On behalf of the Chiefs, Queen Mothers, and people of Afigya Kwabre South Constituency, and in particular the people of Mpobi, I extend heartfelt condolences to the children, the entire family, and the countless Ghanaians whose lives she touched. We have lost a true patriot, a pioneer and a daughter whose legacy will endure for generations.

May her gentle soul rest in peace, and may the almighty God grant her eternal rest.

Mr Speaker, I thank you. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Statements are ably read,

and it is now time for your comments. I give the floor to Mr Mahama Shaibu.

Mr Mahama Shaibu (NDC — Daboya/Mankarigu): Mr Speaker, I am exceedingly grateful to our two Colleagues for the Statements they have ably made. Indeed, the preamble to Ms Zuwera Ibrahimah's Statement acknowledging the deaths of innocent females was so touching. I pray that their souls rest in perfect peace.

Mr Speaker, three words were used to describe the ideals of Nana Konadu Agyeman- Rawlings; courage, fortitude, and the last one was boldness. Indeed, she echoed it in Sunyani, and it resonated with the female folks of this country. The girl child had somebody to look up to. Many years ago, when the girl child did not have hope, she singularly started and championed a movement, of course, joined by other gallant women of this country. Today, all the hopes that the girl child has can be traced to Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings.

Perhaps one very important thing that we have often lost sight of, which leaves an indelible mark, is her push for the promulgation of the Intestate Succession Act, 1985 (PNDC Law 111), that got women out of the doldrum. She did it at a time this was against her own ethnic background, the matrilineal heritage. So that boldness to move against her own tradition, for the sake of women and children, is an indelible mark that ought to be remembered.

Mr Speaker, every day we say our Prayers, we recognise the efforts of great men and women in this country. One of the standards in our Prayer, is that,

“Oh God, bless the efforts of those who struggle to make the vision a living reality”.

Each and every day we say this, Prayer; it is a thought that goes to the likes of Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings. May Allah be pleased with her. Thank you, Mr Speaker and the makers of these Statements.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Mrs Gizella Akushika Tetteh-Agbotui?

Mrs Gizella Akushika Tetteh-Agbotui (NDC — Awutu Senya West): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I rise to thank the makers of the two Statements in honour of Her Excellency Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings.

Mr Speaker, I know Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings as an in-law because I am also married to her husband's first cousin. So, along the way, I got to appreciate her as a woman in politics, but with a lot of family values. One thing I noticed was that she had a very strong conviction about issues, and when she starts to discuss them, it does not matter where you stand in family, she has her points made forcefully and directly.

We all know the kind of grassroots mobilisation tendencies that she had. The 31st December Women's Movement was not an ordinary movement at that time, and to be able to lead such a group of

women across the country with their typical red berets that they all wore around the country, and to consider all the activities they were able to undertake to empower themselves at that grassroots level, is commendable. And it was realised that she took her own path while husband also had his path of being a President. She was a very dynamic First Lady, who went down to the grassroots to get and had a feel of the local woman and what she goes through economically, socially, and culturally.

I recall when she established her party, I think the tagline was, “Be Bold”. For people who knew her, it was not surprising that she had that tagline, because she herself, I think, was a very bold woman. Even though she was physically small in stature, she was bold in her characteristic headgear that she took off only five per cent of the time. She was bold in her views and in being a woman in politics. She really led the way. She may not have been a Member of Parliament, a Minister, a Deputy, or any of those. She did hold a position in the National Democratic Party. But you could tell that, at least, she stood her ground as the wife of the longest serving President in Ghana and history will be kind with her.

Mr Speaker, she left behind four lovely children who, if you look at the time at which they were born and brought up, she managed to steer the affairs of her family and managed to keep her family intact. That shows in the great comradeship that we have with our Colleague, Dr Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlings, in the House.

I think that she was not celebrated enough as an individual. Sometimes, there are some controversies; it happens in politics. But all said and done, Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings has played her part in the history of this country, in the history of women in politics, and the history of the NDC Party as a whole. We wish her a restful journey to the ancestors.

Thank you.

5:58 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Hon Gizella Tetteh-Agbotui.

I will give the floor to Hon Alhassan Suhuyini.

Alhaji Suhuyini Sayibu Alhassan (NDC — Tamale North): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to contribute to this beautiful Statement presented by the Hon Member of Parliament for Salaga South, in honour of the late First Lady of the Republic of Ghana, Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings.

Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings is the heroine of our childhood. Some of us grew up, and she was our first experience of a woman with power and authority. One who used it as a force of change, positive change, which inspired many in our generation to reach out to achieve more.

Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings was not only a trailblazer for her generation, but through her works and her activities, she inspired the

generations that followed right after hers. I recall when education was not very popular in many parts of this country, especially the rural areas. She dared to champion education even for the girl child, even when education for the boy child was not that popular. By her deeds and acts, it became so common. And today, it is a fact that at the basic level, we tend to have more girl students than we do for male students. It was because of this campaign that she led, with a song that many of us can still remember.

[The Hon Member sang “Send Your Girl Child to School”]

This was what we heard on the radio in the morning and afternoon, and that defied the traditional belief, at the time, that the place for the woman or girl was in the kitchen or the market. Because of her activities and how she mobilised market women and women in general in the communities, as well as took an active part in the building of our communities, it became easier for parents who had girl children to dream that kind of life for their children and give them that opportunity.

So, indeed, her loss is not just one for her immediate family. Even as we condole with them, it is important that we remind them that the loss is felt by all patriotic citizens of this land because she laid her life and used her youthful energy to help in building this country by creating the platform that we all stand on today. On this note, I wish to extend my

heartfelt condolences to our Colleague, Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlings, for the loss and pray that the Almighty Allah—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Her name is Zanetor.

Alhaji Alhassan: Zanetor—I am sure she would not forgive me for not pronouncing the name well, because I have had private tutorials on how to pronounce it. Yes, my heartfelt condolences to her and her siblings. I pray that the good Lord will give her the strength and the serenity of mind that she requires to lead the family in these difficult times.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Yes, Minister for Education?

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu) (MP): Mr Speaker, let me thank the makers of the Statement, Hon Zuwera and our Colleague for the opportunity to pay tribute to Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings, former First Lady of the Republic of Ghana, who undoubtedly made a remarkable contribution to the social, political and economic development of our country.

Mr Speaker, for those of us in the New Democratic Congress (NDC), Nana

Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings was a critical financier of the NDC, particularly given the historical evolution of the NDC being birthed by the Provisional National Defence Council (PNDC). It took a lot of courage and investment to get the NDC resilient and viral as it is today. Sometimes, when I see what our Colleagues on the other Side, the New Patriotic Party (NPP) are going through today, we probably went through worse in 2001 in this Republic, when we lost power in the year 2000.

I still recall, that part of it was reforming the NDC itself. I made this comment, and I want to repeat it for the record, that sometimes when we are angry, we should manage our anger. That is one of the fundamental lessons the departure of Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings must teach those of us within the political group and the political elites of our country, to be measured in what we do. I say so because at the time, if we recall the NDC Congress, there was one at the Trade Fair and another in Tamale, and we were building a political party with people from diverse backgrounds.

My first encounter, Mr Speaker, with Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings was when I was growing up in Tamale. There was a day on the 31st December Women's Movement, she came to commission a bakery at a home closer to mine in Tamale. And for that, we want to celebrate her for her extraordinary contribution to women's empowerment

in Ghana and Africa. She led the way; the 31st December Women's Movement led the way. At least, If for nothing, Mr Speaker, the consciousness it created in our women to know and demand their rights is to her credit.

Then, as I said, in the building of the NDC as a party, I was having a word with Dr Obed Asamoah, who then was National Chairman. I served under him as National Youth Organiser. He reminded me of the critical role, because at the time, she knew people, so she could reach out to persons to support the NDC.

Mr Speaker, do you know why the NDC is strong today? Because there were a group of young people, including the Majority Leader now, who had formed a youth forum and related to President Rawlings and the family, we did not want to romanticise Rawlings without building structures for the NDC as a party. So, we learned from the CPP lesson, the romance of Nkrumah or "Nkrumahism", but, there were no structures on the ground. We told President Rawlings, at the time, to let us build a political party, so that tomorrow, we will make him proud. This was between 2001 and 2004, very struggling days for the NDC. But today, we have a formidable political party, which is governing.

So, to Hon Zuwera, and to our Colleague Zanetor, I pray that God will give her and her siblings the fortitude to

accept the loss. The loss of an icon of a woman. Even in our democratic journey, she played her part.

Mr Speaker, permit me to conclude by saying that, given the temperament at the time of the late President Rawlings, we can only credit that strong woman and that strong voice of a sobering personality, that sobered President Rawlings, who ruled this country for a period of 19 years. Not easy. I mean, even getting Ghana transiting from a state-dominated economy to a liberalised economy, we owe it to that period. Transiting Ghana from an authoritarian, autocratic regime to a democratic regime, we owe it to that period.

6:08 p.m.

So Mr Speaker, this is the woman we are celebrating, Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings. She paid her dues, she played her part in the building of our democracy, but more importantly, in the empowerment of women. I am sure her popular word, 'Be Bold', was to tell us that we should be courageous in standing by the truth and upholding the value of honesty. May her soul rest in perfect peace, and I do convey my profound sympathies and condolences to the family. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, based on the agreement, may we observe one minute's silence.

[A minute's silence was observed for H.E. the Former First Lady, Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings]

May her soul rest in perfect peace.
Amen.

Yes?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib (NPP — Weija-Gbawe): Mr Speaker, I know that I have missed a very important opportunity to have contributed to this Statement, Mr Speaker, for very important reasons. But I will let it slide. I am sure I will see you in chambers and tell you why it would have been important for me to have made a statement on this matter.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I have been looking at your Side to see whether there was an expression of interest.

We now move to the third Statement, standing in the name of Mavis Kuukua Bissie, Member of Parliament for Ahanta West.

Hon Member, you have the floor.

Protecting and Developing Ghana's Forest Reserves into Ecotourism Destinations for Revenue Generation

Ms Mavis Kuukua Bissie (NDC — Ahanta West): Thank you, Mr Speaker, I rise to make a Statement on the urgent need for Ghana to protect and transform its forest reserves into a well-managed ecotourism destination that will generate sustainable revenue for the nation, create employment opportunities and preserve

our natural environment. Mr Speaker, Ghana is richly endowed with several forest reserves that are essential to maintaining our ecological balance and driving economic growth. These include Ankasa Conservation Area, Bia National Park, Atewa Range Forest Reserve, Tano-Offin Forest Reserve, Suburi River Forest Reserve, Shai Hills Reserve, Kakum National Park and the Cape Three Points Forest Reserve in Ahanta West. These forests contain unique species of flora and fauna, beautiful rivers, waterfalls and scenic landscapes that could make Ghana a leading ecotourism destination in West Africa if properly developed.

Despite their vast potential, many of these forest reserves are being destroyed at an alarming rate. Illegal mining, sand weaning, logging and encroachment for residential and commercial purposes continue to deplete our forest cover. These destructions not only threaten biodiversity but also deprives the nation of valuable sources of revenue, employment and long-term environmental stability. Out of the 288 forest reserves, 44 have been completely destroyed. A total of 5,500 hectares of forest lands, equivalent to 7,500 football fields, need to be reclaimed. Mr Speaker, in the western region, particularly within the Ahanta West Municipality, the situation is deeply concerning. The Cape Three Points Forest Reserve, Ghana's southernmost forest and one of the most biologically diverse in the country, is under severe threat from illegal mining

and logging. Once a lush green sanctuary is now experiencing widespread destruction. The National Anti-Illegal Mining Task Force (NAIMOS), recently entered the forest to arrest illegal miners, yet the problem persists, demonstrating that enforcement alone is not enough. There must be a sustainable economic alternative that motivates communities to protect the forest rather than destroy it.

Mr Speaker, Ghana has strong legal frameworks governing the protection and management of forest reserves. These include Forest Act 1927 (Act 157), the Timber Resources Management Act 1997 (Act 547), the Environmental Protection Agency Act 1994 (Act 490), and the Minerals and Mining Act 2006 (Act 703). Every year, government invests significant resources through these institutions and other agencies to protect forests across the country. However, despite these efforts, enforcement alone has not yielded the desired results. Violations persist and many forest reserves have been encroached upon, degraded, and in some cases converted into mining concessions and residential settlements.

Government continues to fight against illegal mining and logging. However, if our forest reserves remain under protection without being turned into productive economic assets, these illegal activities will not stop. Authorities frequently enter the forests to arrest offenders, yet others return the next day to continue the same practices. This is

because many people living in communities around forest reserves have no alternative livelihoods. For most of them, illegal mining and logging have become their only source of income.

Mr Speaker, transforming forest reserves into ecotourism destinations will provide a lasting and sustainable solution to this challenge. Ecotourism will create decent and reliable jobs, empower local people economically, and give them a sense of ownership and responsibility toward protecting the forests. When communities benefit directly from tourism-related activities such as guiding, hospitality, craft sales, and local transport, they will no longer engage in illegal mining or logging. This approach will reduce pressure on our forests, promote conservation, and stimulate rural economies across Ghana.

6:18 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the Cape Three Points area is a remarkable natural wonder where a rare phenomenon, locally known as the "Blood Sky," occurs during full moon evenings, painting the horizon red at sunset. This breathtaking spectacle coincides with the migration of dolphins, whales, and other marine species that frequent the surrounding waters, making Cape Three Points the ecological and experiential highlight of the Gulf of Guinea. Beyond its scenic beauty, the area serves as a critical marine ecosystem where natural seasonal cycles create pauses in fishing activities,

allowing for the replenishment of fish stocks and the preservation of marine biodiversity, including dolphins and whales.

Mr Speaker, Cape Three Points serve as a vital habitat for both forest and marine species. The area hosts unique birds such as the Rock Pigeon, Red-eyed Dove, Western Plantain-eater, and the endemic Ahanta Spurfowl, as well as important mammals including the lesser spot-nosed monkey, white-naped mangabey, and bottlenose dolphin. Together with whales and other marine life, these species make Cape Three Points an ecological treasure that highlights the urgent need for its protection and development into a sustainable ecotourism destination for national revenue and biodiversity conservation.

Mr Speaker, Ahanta West is not only blessed with the Cape Three Points Forest Reserve. The Municipality also has other attractive tourism resources, including two crocodile ponds at Prince's Akatekyi and Egyembra, a waterfall at Ezile popularly known as Akwidaa, four historical forts at Butre, Dixcove, Akwidaa, and Cape Three Points, picturesque beaches, and the Cape Three Points Lighthouse. Where these natural and cultural sites are properly developed, they can generate substantial revenue for the government, create employment, boost local businesses, and make Ahanta West a

major tourism hub in the Western Region.

Mr Speaker, in the light of the immense ecological, cultural, and economic potential of the Cape Three Points Forest area, I wish to make the following appeals to Government for consideration and immediate action.

Leverage the black sky phenomenon at Cape Three Pointss to develop a sustainable, world-class ecotourism experience that attracts both local and international visitors.

Transform the Cape Three Points Forest reserve into a tourism eco-park to serve as a model for sustainable tourism. Combine forest conservation with recreational, educational, and research opportunities that create jobs and boost the local economy.

Integrate ecotourism with the Blue Harvest Fisheries Initiative to promote sustainable fishing, protect marine biodiversity, and support the livelihoods of coastal communities.

Position Ahanta West Municipality as a high-value destination for international tourists, environmental researchers, and conservationists by improving infrastructure, marketing, and conservation management.

Promote community participation and benefit sharing to ensure local residents gain direct employment and income from tourism, thereby reducing their independence on illegal mining and logging.

Encourage public-private partnerships to attract investment into ecologists, research centres, and cultural tourism projects within Cape Three Points and its surrounding communities.

Support marine forest conservation education programmes to raise awareness of the importance of protecting biodiversity while promoting sustainable livelihoods.

Include Cape Three Points in Ghana's national tourism and conservation master plan to ensure long-term government commitment, funding, and effective environmental management.

Mr Speaker, our forests are not just trees; they are living ecosystems that sustain our water resources, regulate our climate, and provide countless economic opportunities. If managed wisely, they can drive Ghana's economic growth, create jobs, and enhance our global reputation as a sustainable tourism destination.

These and many more advantages are the reasons we must collectively answer the call to transform and protect our forest reserves into a well-managed ecotourism destination that will generate revenues, create jobs, and preserve our natural forest. *Ayinda, yekoo ye anyunu, yelesiali ye meda.* To wit, this time, Ahanta moves forward, unstoppable, united, no return. Mr Speaker, I respectfully so submit and thank you for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Hon Members, it is for

your contribution. Yes, Hon Member for Takoradi?

Mr Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah (NPP — Takoradi): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, I also extend greetings to Hon Kuukua Bissie.

Mr Speaker, the topic on making our forests ecotourism is key to national development. If we take the country, Ghana, and we locate all the mines in this country from Newmont, AngloGold Ashanti, Obuasi, AngloGold Ashanti, Iduapriem, Duaman, and the rest, we realise that virtually all of them are in the forest or next to a forest. Mr Speaker, when we take Newmont, it is in the Afrisipakrom Forest. Newmont, Akyempim is also in the Bepo Forest in Akyem. AngloGold Ashanti in Obuasi is in the Obuasi Forest. Iduapriem is in the New Forest in Takwa.

So clearly, we realise that all the miners, both large scale and illegal, know that all the forest belt we have in this country are forest zones. So, the question we ask ourselves is that how did we do this to ourselves, that we built plantations and forest reserves in the mines or above the mines? I believe that this is one area that we need to critically look at and see how best we can make sure that in our next set of activities, we will build these forest reserves outside mining zones, or areas that are not endowed with mineral resources. This is so that we can reduce the menace or the potential attempt of people getting into these forests to destroy them and get

access to the mineral wealth of this country.

I believe the one way we can do so is to make sure that we take advantage of the carbon credit system that is coming up in the world. Mr Speaker, Ghana is estimated to have a potential revenue generation pattern of about US\$6.5 billion from carbon credit of our forests. This clearly means that for every forest we have in the country, the over 283 forest reserves, each of them can be earning a minimum of about US\$4.7 million every year. Clearly, this means that the communities around these forest zones can partner with governments and be part owners of these forest reserves and get some of these monies. I believe that at least half of that money should be given to these communities as salaries for equipment, and also to equip them to protect these forests.

If these illegal miners are destroying these forests by using hard equipment, we should be able to train our own community members and equip them to face them, then we will know that the monies we will get from the carbon credit, we will use some to support these communities to develop and give opportunities to the people around these areas.

Mr Speaker, I also do believe that the time has come that this country takes a hard look at the issue of the issuance of licences to miners. In fact, it is time we move away from this centralised system and move to a more peer-reviewed system of districts, so that we are sure that we can equip the district assemblies,

the district mining communities for issuing the licence and also making sure that they can control the miners that illegally go into these forests. Where the forests have been destroyed, they should be able to reclaim them and replant them anew at the district level. We should not be awarding these contracts from Accra, because consistently we have seen that anytime we make such an attempt, the money does not go down and we all see these forests being destroyed.

Mr Speaker, it is possible that we can reclaim all these forests that have been destroyed. According to the World Economic Forum, when we invest US\$1 into forest reclamation and replanting, we get a minimum of US\$7, all the way up to about US\$30. So clearly, if Government takes a decision to invest in the reclamation and replanting of these forests, Ghana, in the long run, is going to make profits. These profits can be ploughed back into these communities to support them to protect these forests and make sure that we can get all the biodiversity we need for our pharmaceuticals and agriculture, and for other benefits that we are looking for, especially carbon capture, that are needed by the plants, and also climate change issues as well.

Mr Speaker, I believe that we need to be more strategic and firmer to make sure that we take the bull by the horn and invest in these communities, so that they can protect our forests going forward.

Mr Speaker, I am so happy that when the Hon Member was making the Statement, she found a way to weave the

story of Ahanta West into it. She has done so well to tell us all the potential in the Ahanta West are. But I believe that in creating and making these forest zones into ecotourism centres, there are so many things that we need to look at, both tangibles and intangibles.

6:28 p.m.

Mr Speaker, for the special case of the Ahanta people, like their own blood brothers, the people of Ashanti and Wassa, these are very hospitable people who can always manage people, and make sure people live within their midst. And then also— Mr Speaker, I would finish very soon. The area is very attractive for tourism.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, it is not that you would finish very soon. The Rules stipulate the time period within which a Member is to comment on a Statement. So, where the Rules are deliberately being violated, I am worried. I indicated from the beginning that we have a lot of Statements, so if we can all be brief, it would be better for all of us.

Mr Darko-Mensah: All right.

Mr Speaker, in concluding, I would like to use this opportunity—Since we are talking about ecotourism and the forest and the tangibles and the intangibles, I believe that we need to put into clusters some of the festivals and events that happen in the Western Region and the Ahanta West area in particular, the Ankos, the Ahanta Fest,

and the Yesu Asor, that complements the ecotourism agenda my Sister was trying to set for the Ahanta West.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to be a part of the Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment.

Dr Abdul-Rashid Hassan Pelpuo (NDC — Wa Central): Mr Speaker, I would like to also thank the maker of the Statement, Ms Mavis Kuukua Bissie, for such a wonderful Statement. From the Statement, it shows that she is very committed to seeing a clean and purified forest, which has been of use to Ghana since our independence.

Mr Speaker, Ghana is rich for several reasons, but the most important reason is because we have a forest. Our cocoa, timber and farms are from the forest. It has huge potential for Ghana and has created a lot of job opportunities for the country. We have kept a good forest throughout our lives from independence until *galamsey* and small-scale mining came into being.

Since then, it has been a question of whether we can maintain the 288 forest reserves we have in this country or not. Mr Speaker, out of this number, so much of it has gone to waste already and is being reclaimed with a lot of difficulty. It tells a long story about ourselves, whether we want to sustain our economic development or we want to go back to a situation of poverty and want.

Mr Speaker, it is very clear that the preservation of the forest must be a responsibility for every Ghanaian, not just any government that comes into being. Of course, the government's supervision is critical, but the overall need for the forest to remain a forest must be to every Ghanaian. I just hope that this Statement that is made should not just be a Statement on the floor of Parliament. It should trigger a committed resolve for us to take back our forest.

Yesterday, I spoke to one of the officers of our water company. He laments that in many places now, it is difficult to purify the water. It is so contaminated, and people are going without water. It is a shame that at this stage of our lives, we can still allow such a thing to happen. So, as she was reading her Statement, my mind went back to all the things happening to our forest, and we are so much condescending to it.

Let me just thank the Ministry for Lands and Natural Resources for the commitment shown by constructing ways to reclaim part of our forest. I understand that about 1,000 hectares of our forest reserve is now being reclaimed, and about 32,000 hectares of the forest would be reclaimed very soon. This is a commitment we all have to put our heads together to support.

I also heard people talk about the need for us to declare a state of emergency because of the widespread destruction of our forest. It has never been the promise of anybody to do so. But because people are so anxious about it, we are working on the letter itself to make sure a lot is

done. I can say that the number of people who were in the forest and destroying it, lots of them have been arrested, many have been sacked, and those who have moved into the rivers, and are also washing the gold in it and destroying it, are also being tackled. But we need to do more.

There are those who are asking that because the life of Ghana is directly linked to the forest, military people should go and then destroy the people who are doing so, the equipment they are using, and all that, and then shoot at them. Even though it is not admirable and advisable to do so, it tells of the critical need for us to take strong actions to preserve our forests.

Mr Speaker, the Statement brings it out very clearly that we do not have to sit down and wait until destruction occurs. I want to support her prescriptions for it, and the subsequent speakers who have called for immediate strong action to make sure we preserve our forests. We need our lands, we need the forests, and I agree with her, the forests are not just about trees, it is about a whole ecosystem, and preservation of life. In the forest, as Mahatma Gandhi said, "when the last tree dies, the last man dies".

So, this is a warning to us. I believe that with a combination of the climate change occurring and those of us who do not care and are contributing to it, a policy must take the next step to make sure that a comprehensive attempt is made to save our forests.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Member.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, bearing in mind the Rules, and I know how critical you have been this afternoon, I intend to be brief. Let me start off by commending our Colleague from the Ahanta area who has set the tone for this consciousness of our forests as a huge resort which is in a dormant state, and our needs as a nation to exploit.

Mr Speaker, it is interesting fact that about more than 90 per cent of the forest reserve we have in this country have minerals. I am reliably informed that one of our colonial masters handed this to us. It is quite ironic, the minerals are found in the forest, to do or not to do. As a nation, have we come to a point where we have to decide to find an alternative, go and exploit the forest that has the minerals, and build alternative forests? That is a begging question that has been haunting every government now and then, and as a nation, we need to come to terms and be practical. That is what it is.

It is not true that governments that have come and gone have been issuing small-scale licenses for people to mine in the forest reserve.

6:38 p.m.

That is not true. The activities that have been going on there is total illegality. They do not have the blessings of authorities. I can tell you now Government is not doing it; previous Governments did not do it. But the crux of the matter is that the minerals are found where the forest is.

Mr Speaker, beyond that, ever since we signed on to—

Alhaji S. S. Alhassan — *rose* —

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Does the Hon Member want to take me on a point of order? Well, he has to catch the eye of Mr Speaker.

Ever since we signed on to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) globally, the dynamics and the narrative have changed. So, the industrialised world is eager to exchange with us as developing countries of the world.

Now, the current narrative is the carbon credit and the carbon trade. Ghana, as a developing country, last year, out of the carbon trade alone, raked in over US\$2 billion from Switzerland. That is a low-hanging fruit. I know there is another exchange with South Korea, and there is a potential of another over US\$2 billion that will rake in. Why? Just for the protection of our forests. So, the mere protection of your forests, inclusive of flora and fauna, will rake in billions of dollars without any effort. That, for me, is the call of our Colleague and all of us should be revolving around this call. So, the forest, just like the ocean, is a huge resource, and something must be done about it.

China, with all the claims that they are indulging in pollution, is reclaiming the desert. So, nothing under the sun is impossible. It is high time climate justice and the polluter pay principle, which has

been accepted globally, becomes part of the narrative. Otherwise, we are just joking. We will just be talking and moving in cycles. Who does not know about the Ahanta Region that there is a huge potential in terms of forests? But go there now and see the destruction with impunity; you cannot describe it.

Mr Speaker, I think we can talk on and on, but let me conclude on the relevance of the National Commission for Civic Education (NCCE). When we were young and growing up as young pioneers, there were programmes on national television, apart from our civic responsibilities—*[Interruption]*—Listen to me.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You are not to answer any questions emanating from them.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Thank you, Mr Speaker, for protecting me. They are just envious of me.

So NCCE, you find programmes dedicated on national television in which we are told how to protect, apart from our civic responsibility, of the environment (flora and fauna) was part of our civic responsibility? Today, these things no longer exist.

Mr Speaker, I see you are eager for me to conclude. These are the things we should be speaking to as a nation, and for me, that is what will make the difference. Beyond that, it will just be long and winding speeches, which will not go to affect the core of the problem at hand.

But let me commend the maker of the Statement, and request of you, Mr Speaker, that copies are forwarded to the relevant ministries: Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources, the Ministry of Environment, Science and Technology, for them to make good use of it and see how they can change the narrative. These are cross-cutting issues.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Yes, Leaders, are you yielding? Yes, Hon Sayibu?

Alhaji S. S. Alhassan: Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement.

I do not intend to belabour the point. I think that all the relevant issues related to the forests, and the need for us to preserve it, have already been made. I therefore wish to commend the maker of the Statement. I also, to a very large extent, agree with the contributions that have come from members. Except that, Mr Speaker, I just wish to caution that there is a particular narrative out there that is not born out of facts, and when it is presented as though it was a fact, it sends misleading signals.

Mr Speaker, I have heard being peddled by people in authority that our forest reserves sit on gold mines, and that our colonial masters deliberately planted these forest reserves around gold mines. I am yet to find single evidence of that

from any formal or responsible institution. It remains a rumour. And when you find people in responsible positions repeating that narrative, it serves as encouragement, in my view, to people who are environmental terrorists. They make it a justification that our forests reserves were deliberately planted at gold mines, so they will go and mine the gold and perhaps determine new areas to cultivate new forest reserves. I would want us to hasten slowly in repeating such commentary publicly, especially on formal platforms, until we have evidence to back that claim.

Mr Speaker, I just want to make this contribution to correct that impression, apart from that I agree with almost all the contributions that have been made, and I share in the appeal to you to probably make copies of the Statement available to some of the relevant ministries for study and action where it is necessary.

I thank you very much for the opportunity, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, by the agreement, we have come to the end of comment for this Statement, and accordingly, I will direct the Table Office to make copies of the Statement available to the Ministry of Environment, Science and Technology as well as the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources.

We move to another Statement, standing in the name of Hon Member for

Manso Nkwanta, Mr Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo.

Hon Member, you have the floor.

Dealing with Labour Unrests in Ghana

Mr Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo (NPP — Manso Nkwanta): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, labour unrest remains one of the most persistent socio-economic challenges in Ghana, especially within the public sector. Over the years, various categories of workers, including teachers, nurses, doctors, have resorted to strikes and demonstrations to express their dissatisfaction with working conditions, remuneration, and policy implementation.

While labour agitation is not unique to Ghana, its recurrence and impact on national productivity demand urgent and proactive solutions. Mr Speaker, rather than waiting for industrial action to escalate into full-blown strikes or threats to national stability, authorities must embrace a preventive approach that addresses the root causes of these unrests. A proactive stance involves anticipating workers' concerns, strengthening communication, fulfilling obligations, involving stakeholders in policy-making, and investing in institutional reforms that build mutual trust between the state and its workforce.

One of the most recurring grievances among workers is their delay in salary negotiation, arrears, and unfulfilled allowances.

6:48 p.m.

Public sector workers, particularly those in essential services like health and education, often feel undervalued by remuneration structures that do not reflect the rising cost of living.

Mr Speaker, many public workers operate in difficult environments with inadequate resources, outdated equipment and unsafe facilities. For instance, health care workers in rural areas frequently lack basic tools and teachers are forced to operate in overcrowded and poorly maintained classrooms. Labour unions mostly feel they are not involved in policy decisions that affect their welfare. This creates a sense of exclusion and builds resentment.

Mr Speaker, pledges to improve conditions of service are often made but not implemented, leading to mistrust and agitation. The delay in addressing complaints through formal institutions like the National Labour Commission leads many workers to believe that strikes are the only way to be heard. In ensuring harmonious labour relations, being proactive is key. This means taking deliberate steps to prevent a problem from occurring. This involves constant engagement, transparent communication and a commitment to fairness and justice in the treatment of workers. The reactive approach, where there are interventions after workers have gone on strike, is costly and damaging.

Strikes in essential services such as healthcare or utilities can result in loss of

lives, disrupted economic activity and social instability. A proactive approach ensures that workers' issues are addressed before they become unbearable. Trust is built between the government and employees, service delivery to the public is not disrupted, and Ghana's reputation as a stable investment destination is preserved.

To adopt a proactive approach, there must be mechanisms developed that continuously monitor and assess worker satisfaction and act early on emerging issues. The role of the National Labour Commission should be enhanced through proper funding, independence and authority to make binding decisions. A stronger commission can swiftly mediate disputes and prevent strikes from happening. The Government must also have dedicated labour relations unions trained in dispute resolution and employee engagement.

Mr Speaker, the Government must prioritise the timely payment of salaries and allowances and engage unions during the formulation of policies that affect workers. Establish consultative forums between the government and key labour unions that will promote trust and mutual understanding. Addressing the physical and logistical challenges faced by workers is essential. This includes renovating schools, supplying health facilities with adequate equipment and ensuring access to safety tools for security personnel. Investing in the work environment is a sign of respect for workers and enhances productivity.

Again, an early warning system could be developed that monitors signs of labour dissatisfaction through regular surveys, media monitoring and feedback platforms. This allows authorities to identify early signals of discontent and act quickly before issues escalate.

Mr Speaker, communication is key. Workers are more likely to become agitated when they feel ignored or misinformed. Being proactive will ensure open, honest and timely communication between state agencies and workers. Responsible institutions should regularly update the public and labour groups on progress made towards fulfilling agreements, and leaders must avoid over-promising and under-delivering. Credibility is key to maintaining peace.

Mr Speaker, additionally, transparency in resource allocation helps workers to understand the challenges the government may be facing. If workers see that their concerns are being addressed within the limits of national resources, they may become more patient and cooperative.

As a way forward, labour unrest poses a major threat to economic progress, social harmony and public well-being. However, the solution lies not only in responding to strikes when they occur, but in putting systems in place that anticipate and prevent such disruptions. Ghana must shift from a reactive to a proactive labour engagement strategy, which involves strengthening institutional capacity, paying salaries

and benefits on time, improving infrastructure and work conditions, and engaging labour unions in decision-making.

If these measures are consistently applied, Ghana will not only reduce the frequency of its strikes but also build a more motivated and productive workforce. Proactive labour management is not just a governance strategy; it is a national imperative. The earlier these are acted upon, the better for its citizens and the future of the country.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment.

Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment (Dr Abdul-Rashid Hassan Pelpuo) (MP): Mr Speaker, let me thank the maker of the Statement for such a Statement which directly affects the labour force in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, the Government, under my leadership, has shown enough commitment to ensuring that labour and their concerns are addressed each time they present issues that have a direct influence on their work. We are aware that a successful economy depends on a motivated labour force, and at any point in time, we notify the labour force of the concerns we have about them and how we are working towards achieving them. The issues the Hon Member expressed directly touch on the policies I am embarking on right now.

Mr Speaker, we are committed to doing one very important thing. Having worked at the Ministry for a while, I noticed that there has always been a long gap between government and labour. So, a key policy initiative I have is to ensure that, before the end of the year, Labour and the Government will have a seminar or a conference. The economy defines whether labour is going to be supported in what they demand or not, and so it is important that we keep them informed about the nature of the economy at every point in time.

6:58 p.m.

The idea of staying on until the end of the year when negotiations are made between labour and Government, or in the Tripartite Committee, when employers, Government and the labour itself begin to talk about base salary and minimum wage, is no longer an admirable thing we want to continue. We think that at least in every half a year, we should have a seminar to respond to the challenge he is talking about, that there must be some kind of relation between the two, or between labour and employers and government, so we can always come to a certain conclusion in how we tackle issues.

Mr Speaker, at the moment, what we are doing is to say that at any point in time labour has concern about their allowances, arrears and other conditions of service, we will not let it drag until they begin to go on strike. Along with the Minister for Finance, we have put in

place systems by which we can tackle these issues before we hear Organised Labour say they want to go on strike. If we want to reset this country, it is important that labour is consistently taken care of, labour understands the kind of economy we run, the kind of leadership we have, and these are critical issues for us. So, for the public to get to understand, our commitment is that we will work with labour in their conditions of service at any point in time, long before they begin to show anger. We will also make sure we have relations in terms of organising seminars for them to understand the economy and the policies of Government, to put them on in response to the maker of the Statement saying it is important for us to make sure we put them in shape in understanding the kind of policies Government runs. These are important issues that he raised, and I would like to commend him for that, and also assure labour that the commitment we spell to them at the end of the negotiation, the present negotiation of baseline and minimum salaries, are going to work, and we promise to do so. Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Dr Mahama?

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama (NPP — Walewale): Mr Speaker, first and foremost, I would like to commend Mr Fokuo for this Statement. This Statement is timely, especially when Government has just concluded the base pay negotiation with Public Sector Workers. To bring our attention to this matter means that after this event, we

may have to look at how we address sustainably the concern of workers.

Mr Speaker, labour unrest is a source of worry, and not just in Ghana. Across the world, whenever we have labour unrest, productivity is grounded. Once productivity is grounded, it means that other sectors of the economy is equally affected. In fact, a day of unrest can cause a country several millions of Ghana cedis. That is a situation we do not want to encounter. The maker of the Statement has brought our attention to one key issue. The issue is that we need to have a proactive labour response system. A response system that is anchored on transparent remuneration structure for workers. That is the gravamen of the call and the appeal made by the respected Colleague on this particular Statement.

Mr Speaker, factor productivity, in other words, the productivity of labour as a factor of production is anchored on incentive. That is one cardinal determinant of whether or not workers are going to give value. If we look at Parliament, the ability of staff to give results depends on the remuneration structure that they enjoy. If we want to be a country that put premium on outcome or on result or output, we must look at how we take care of workers. Apart from remuneration, they also look at their pension scheme. What is the security for me after I have served my country diligently after some time? Without a good pension scheme for workers, they

would be agitated. If I look at my salary and my salary is not anything to write home about and I look at my future and it is bleak, I will have every reason to always be agitated against the authority of the Government or against my employers.

Mr Speaker, the last thing is also to look at other incentive schemes. Aside pension and salary, are there other allowances? For instance, what explains a worker after working for the country or employer for 30 years, only to be thrown out of the house by the landlord? That is something that, again, many workers do not want to hear. So, labour unrest is a factor of some of these reasons I have mentioned and we need to look at them. The problem then is; we do not have a predictable scheme for the determination of the conditions of service of the workers. There is no predictability whatsoever. Why would a worker end a year without knowing how much they are expected to get the following year? There must be some predictability in the manner we adjust salary of workers in a way that they would be able to even plan for their lives. It will not take the National Tripartite Committee to determine how much workers will take. This negotiation will go on for only one week. In a week, it will determine the fate of workers. That is not something we should countenance or we should tolerate in this particular country because after all is said and done, we know that salary will have to be increased or will have to be reduced depending on the conditions in the country. If that is the understanding, why can one not have a

predictable scheme? A scheme that every worker would know that based on the movement of the economy, this is what we should expect reasonably.

Mr Speaker, there is also the problem of disparity. It is scandalising to know that some employers in Ghana take 100 times what other workers take. We introduced a Single-Spine Salary Structure (SSSS) to address a problem, but I am sorry to say that that scheme has not been able to address the problem we have as a country. There are still huge disparities in terms of salaries, and benefits between workers who serve at the same place or the same employer. If there are huge disparities, there are reasons why some organised labour will have issues to complain. We will need to look at how we review — This is a challenge to the Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment, whether or not we can look at a revision of the SSSS to bring harmony between the various workers so that public workers of different backgrounds are able to get at least equal pay for work of equal value in line with International Labour Organisation requirement.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I want to thank the maker of the statement for bringing our attention to this matter, and I will urge the Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment to ensure that we do everything to avert labour unrest in the country.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Hon Member.

Yes, Majority Leader, any indication?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we have an early day tomorrow and then a long one, so if we may adjourn now.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, the indication is that we take adjournment.

Yes?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Yes, Mr Speaker, we had an earlier agreement, but I should be agreeing with the Hon Majority Leader because of the events we have scheduled for tomorrow. So, we should adjourn.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader, in view of the fact that we are so close to five hours, but we have not done beyond five hours. Let us do the needful.

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, I move that we adjourn to tomorrow 12 noon.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Motion moved for adjournment, any seconder?

7:10 p.m.

Minority Chief Whip (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh): Mr Speaker, I rise to second the Motion.

I rise to second the Motion.

Question moved and Motion agreed to.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was accordingly adjourned at 7:11 p.m. till Thursday, 13th November, 2025 at 12 noon.

